

The Yellow Duck Phenomenon

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ways to order

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Thesis

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by
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Every possible avenue of knowledge must be explored, every door tried to see if it is open. No kind of evidence need be left untouched on the score of remoteness or complexity, of minuteness or triviality. The tendency of modern enquiry is more and more towards the conclusion that if law is anywhere, it is everywhere.

E.B. Tylor,¹

Searching for the yellow duck. *Thousand words*² is a book with drawings and words. It is a visual dictionary with as many things and words as possible on a page. Sometimes they are in a setting, a context; some pages are specific topics with separate images/words; and sometimes it is only images or words. This book truly was one of my favourites. All the things in the world were in this book. It was ordered chaos. You could find and make your own stories with it. And one thing you were sure of, was of finding a little yellow

1 Tylor, E.B. (1871) p. 24

2 Original title is *The First Thousand Words* by Heather Amery and Stephen Cartwright. I'm using just *Thousand Words* since this is the closest to the way it's translated into Frisian, the language in which I know the book.

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duck in every scene. The duck was the fixed thing. You might not see it - the duck had a habit of hiding behind things - but it was always there. You just had to look for it.

In the first week of this final year studying for my master, I scanned the covers of all my books. I was hoping to give a bit of insight into my head. This obsessive act gave a glimpse, but did not give the answer. For the thesis I had to go a bit beyond the cover. Instead of going for the multitude and deriving the answers from a large amount of different sources, I decided to concentrate on a few specific texts. One text led to another, and so this thesis follows my research in a chronological way.

In a way, this thesis is a search for the yellow duck 2.0. I've been studying at an art academy for six years and now almost at the end of two years master study. It's about time I found the yellow duck in my work, be able to explain the thinking behind my art practice. There is a line in what I do. I can see it, and there are some elements in it I can name. But I can't put my finger on what ties it all together. What is it that I do?

In 1956 A.D. Hall and R.E. Fagen write an introductory chapter for a course at Bell Telephone Laboratories. For their text they used a paper, written in 1950 by Ludwig von Bertalanffy, about the General Systems Theory. Ludwig von Bertalanffy developed his theory further and in 1968 published the book *General System Theory - Foundations, Development, Applications*.

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This book was published by the same publisher that Jack Burnham had. He picked it up, was inspired by it and in 1968 wrote *Systems Aesthetics*. This text, printed in *Artforum*, introduced the systems theory to the 1960s art world.³ So it is not such a big leap from a scientific text written by mathematicians to the late '60s art scene. These texts will be the subject of the first part of my thesis.

To end, I think it is good to make two points clear. First, the Duck from Venturi and Scott Brown in *Learning from Las Vegas* has nothing to do with mine. Their comparison to the Duck was about the form of the Duck relating literally to the function of the building with that form. Their Duck was about the appearance. It was big, it meant to be an eye-catcher and it was white. My Duck isn't physically present. It's small, hiding and very yellow. Second, I don't have the ambition to write a coherent story on System Theory, Structuralism or any other theory, but I do hope to create a coherent and well-argued view on my work by linking it to different texts and by studying them, gaining new insight into my own work. So from all the theories that come up I'll just pick what triggers my interest. And to immediately start by stealing someone else's words: 'I shall be satisfied if it is credited with the modest achievement of having left a difficult problem in a rather less unsatisfactory state than it was before.'⁴

3 Skrebowski, Luke (2006)

4 Lévi-Strauss, Claude (1964) p. 7

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CONCEPT

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*In the last resort, however,
it is always a system of values,
of ideas, of ideologies
- choose whatever word you like -
that is decisive.*

Ludwig von Bertalanffy,⁵

It seems that rules play an important role in my work. In a way you can see a set of rules as a system. The rules work together, influence each other and give a certain outcome. Because of this I will look at systems. How do systems work, what kind of systems are there? Can I relate these back to art and back to my work?

Origin

Ludwig von Bertalanffy (1901-1972) was an Austrian theoretical biologist. When he was 17 he started to study history of art and philosophy and after eight years he finished his PhD. Two years later, in 1928, he published his first book on theoretical biology. In the 1930s he developed the organismic system theory that would form the basis

⁵ Bertalanffy, Ludwig von (1964) p. 245

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for his General Systems Theory. A main feature that he finds in organic systems and uses in his General Systems Theory is the self-regulative capability.

In an open system, that is a system continuously interacting with its environment, there is a mechanism that will try to get the system to a steady state in which there is a minimum of entropy and, hence, a minimum loss of energy. The striving towards this state gives the structure of the system stability.

Bertalanffy brings the concept of the General Systems Theory as one that can be applied in all sciences, not only to, for example, the biology (where he started). It then becomes possible to transfer data from one science to another. This has pushed the study of system theories a lot further.⁶

But instead of using Bertalanffy's book to understand this theory, I'll be taking a text that originates at Bell Telephone Laboratories. It is a summary of the systems theory based, among others, on the text by Bertalanffy. Bell Laboratories, originally founded by the inventor of the telephone Alexander Graham Bell, was the research and development section of AT&T, the American Telephone & Telegraph Company and Western Electric. A small group devoted to basic research was particularly successful. It produced

6 http://isss.org/projects/ludwig_von_bertalanffy, accessed 11 December 2011

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several Nobel prize winners⁷ and was the place where Claude Shannon wrote his paper 'A Mathematical Theory of Communication', the basis for the information theory. The information theory also exerted a big influence on art in the late 60s and early 70s.

A.D. Hall and R.E. Fagen wrote an introductory text in which they discussed the properties of systems in an abstract way. The text was initially written for a course at Bell Telephone Laboratories in New York but was later revised and reprinted in the Yearbook of the Society for the Advancement of General Systems Theory. The society was founded under this name in 1954 by Ludwig von Bertalanffy, Kenneth Boulding, Ralph Gerard and Anatol Rapoport but was generally called Society for General Systems Research (SGSR). It still exists now as the International Society for the Systems Sciences (ISSS).⁸ But in all their records A.D. Hall and R.E. Fagen are not to be found. Whilst their text is used in a vast amount of articles

7 Seven Nobel prizes spread over 13 researchers to be precise: Charge Coupled Device (CCD) (2009):

Willard S. Boyle and George E. Smith.

Fractional Quantum Hall Effect (1998):

Horst Stormer, Robert Laughlin (now at Stanford University), and Daniel Tsui (now at Princeton University).

Optical Trapping (1997):

Steven Chu (now at Stanford University).

Radio Astronomy (1978):

Arno A. Penzias (now retired from Bell Labs) and Robert W. Wilson shared the Nobel Prize in Physics.

Improved Understanding of Local Electronic

States in Solids (1977):

Philip W. Anderson shared the Nobel Prize in Physics.

Transistor (1956):

John Bardeen, Walter H. Brattain and William.

Shockley Wave Nature of Matter (1937):

Clinton J. Davisson.

source: <http://www.alcatel-lucent.com/wps/portal/BellLabs/AwardsandRecognition#tabAnchor2> Accessed 27 December 2011

8 <http://isss.org/world/about-the-isss>, accessed 11 December 2011

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and books on systems and considered a classic, it is not clear who they were exactly.

Definition of System

In 'Definition of System' Hall and Fagen explain in a very clear way the theory of Bertalanffy. It starts with a very general definition of system and then defines the elements and their properties.

*A system is a set of objects together with relationships between the objects and between their attributes.*⁹

So a system consists of objects. These objects have attributes and between both there are relationships. Objects are the parts or components of the system, the attributes properties of the objects and the relationships between them is what ties the system together.¹⁰

In my research for a work I'm looking for relationships between different parts of the subject. These relationships are the key. They are what make systems relevant to my art work. Usually I become fascinated by a topic and start to look in as many directions as I can that are related to it. Between all these side roads, there are from time to time links, similarities. Those things usually end up being important for my work. So actually I'm wondering if you can reason the other way round. If I use in my art the objects that have relationships with other objects (but both from different roads).

⁹ Hall, A.D. and R.E. Fagen (1956) p. 18

¹⁰ Ibid, p. 18

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Is my art a system? And more generally, do all groups of objects that have attributes with relationships make a system?

It is possible to find between any two objects a relationship, how trivial it may be, but a relationship nonetheless. What determines if a relationship is useful or useless is the question that is asked at that particular moment. Changing the question means changing the relevant relationships. The person asking decides the question itself. So systems, how objective and true they might sound or may look on the surface, are at the very beginning totally dependent on the subjective interest of the person asking the question.

So far it is still possible to apply that to art. When making a work of art, it is the artist who decides what question he is asking, or what the subject is. In that sense you could say that the artist is creating a system.

Apart from relationships between objects within a system, there are also parts in or between systems that are identical. So maybe finding these similarities is even more important than relationship when considering my art work. The systems theory talks about isomorphism, something which is structurally identical. Especially in mathematical systems and when you look at systems at an abstract level, this is very often the case. This property can be very handy when studying systems and using one system to apply to another.

Environment

Another element of systems is environment. The definition given by Hall and Fagen for it is:

*For a given system, the environment is the set of all objects a change in whose attributes affect the system and also those objects whose attributes are changed by the behavior of the system.*¹¹

The combination of the objects in the environment and the objects that make the system is called the universe. This universe thus consists of questions that define the system and the environment. These questions are still subjective, as is again dividing the objects of the universe into system or environment. The dividing of objects is a dichotomization, since every object must be either in the system or in the environment. Further, what is in the system can't be in the environment and visa versa. Here the comparison with art doesn't work. You can indeed divide the art in what the art work is and what the public is, but there are lots of works where the public becomes part of the artwork or is asked to participate. It isn't that the public then becomes just part of the art. It is still also a viewer, and in that sense part of the environment. So here I can say that art is not a system, since its components can be part of the system as well part of the environment.

For sciences like physics and chemistry the division of objects is possible and the abstraction will even simplify things. But for fields like biology, sociology and psychology this is a lot more complex. How

11 Hall, A.D. and R.E. Fagen (1956) p. 20

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do these disciplinary fields solve this problem? How can it be applied to the field of arts?

Subsystems

A tool for this could be to divide the system further into subsystems and give them a hierarchical order. The subsystems can be less complex and easier to understand, and understanding the subsystems might give insight into the main system. On the other hand, it could also provide a lot of information that is not relevant to the question at hand. And what makes this method even more complex is that objects that are part of one subsystem could be the environment for another subsystem.¹² So here you can argue two ways. Creating subsystems will make you define the system more precisely. But it could also create an overload of information, making it easy to lose the general point. I think you should strive for precision¹³ and that in the details (subsystems) you can find the general point without having to be general. A detail of the bigger picture will always say something about this bigger picture but will avoid falling into meaningless generalization. A relevant point on this comes from the French naturalist Georges-Louis Leclerc, Comte de Buffon (1707-1788): 'The more we increase the number of divisions in the productions of nature, the closer we shall approach to the true, since nothing really exists in nature, except individuals, and since genera, orders, and classes exist

12 Hall, A.D. and R.E. Fagen (1956) p. 20

13 As is pointed out by 'The Dirty Art Department' several times, their motto being: 'not organized, but precise'. I want to be both since I think that to be truly precise you need, in some respects, to be organized.

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only in our imagination'¹⁴. The subsystem is a term we put on the object, so when we go on dividing the system to the point it is at the core, we end up with the separate element. This element doesn't have any of our interpretation on it, so it is indeed the most true. Maybe this is why they are searching so hard for the undividable particle at CERN¹⁵.

To have a macroscopic view on a system will still leave the problem of how to sort the objects. As the name implies, the 'General Systems Theory' will not be specific, but since a lot has been written about this subject, there are different classes of systems described. These classes have their own properties, and by looking at those properties and finding one that fits the specific question you can make useful connections. They can serve as a tool. The properties given by Hall and Fagen:

Wholeness (coherent) and independence (summative) is one property, a system is to a certain degree coherent (or not). To know what state a system is in helps with the next property. 'Most nonabstract systems change with time. If these changes lead to a gradual transition from wholeness to summativity, the system is said to undergo progressive segregation.'¹⁶ A process in which there is change towards wholeness is

14 **Buffon**, Georges-Louis Leclerc (1749) *Discours sur la manière de traiter l'histoire naturelle* (Oeuvres complètes I, 36 and 39)

15 'CERN, the European Organization for Nuclear Research, is one of the world's largest and most respected centres for scientific research. Its business is fundamental physics, finding out what the Universe is made of and how it works. At CERN, the world's largest and most complex scientific instruments are used to study the basic constituents of matter – the fundamental particles. By studying what happens when these particles collide, physicists learn about the laws of Nature.' source: <http://public.web.cern.ch/public/en/About/About-en.html> Accessed 18 February 2012

16 **Hall**, A.D. and R.E. **Fagen** (1956) p. 22

called progressive systematization. There is also progressive centralization, this is when a system moves towards a system where one part or subsystem plays a dominant role. A system like this is called a centralized system.

Two Kinds of Systems

Then there is the distinction between natural and man-made systems. The important difference between the two is that we have control over the systems we make (man-made). These are systems we understand and can unravel from beginning to end. Whilst natural systems are out of our reach. We are working to understand them, but we can never be sure if we know all there is about them. There is this mystical aspect. When we presume that my work is a system, it is a man-made system. But the inspiration and often the execution of my work lies in the physical world, the environment. This environment consists mostly of man-made systems and also of natural ones. Although I do have a personal interest in nature, it seems that when it comes to art my attention is mostly drawn to man-made things within a natural environment. The only work in which I'm really using a natural system is a concept for a floating neighbourhood in which the houses are close together when the tide is in and spread out when the tide is at its lower point. What is interesting to realize is that man-made systems are often based upon natural systems. The similarities and connections they have are a subject I want to explore more in my work.

Then the last important properties of systems I want to point out. This starts with the fact that natural systems can

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be open or closed. Open systems exchange materials, energies or information with their environment, while closed systems don't. When in exchange with the environment you can have an adaptive system. 'They possess the ability to react to their environments in a way that is favourable, in some sense, to the continued operation of the system.'¹⁷ This is closely related to stable systems in which the variables in the system stay within defined limits. For adaptive systems to function in a favourable way, some variables must remain within certain limits and thus are stable. A system can have stable and unstable parts at the same time. Further, natural systems can be systems with feedback when their output is fed back into the input of the system and has an effect again on the following output. This process influences the stability or instability of a system. An example of an artwork with feedback could be the work *Milton Friedman on the Wonder of the Free Market Pencil*, 41 language alphabetical Google translation loop, starting and finishing in English, 42 digital prints on paper, each 21 x 29.7cm; 2009 of Gareth Kennedy¹⁸. I saw it in the Irish pavilion at the 53rd Venice Biennale in 2009. The artist took a text, translated this in Google, took this translation, translated it again and again and again. The act of translating the text in Google is the system. This system gives an output (the translated text), and this output is again put through the same system (but translated into a different language this time), thus giving a slightly different

17 Hall, A.D. and R.E. Fagen (1956) p. 23

18 <http://www.gkennedy.info/indexhibitv070e/index.php?/kennedy-browne/milton-friedman-on-the-wonder-of-the-freemarket-pe/>
Accessed 11 February 2012

output again. Just note that his use of the system wasn't the subject of the work. The system was a tool.

The properties given for natural systems can be related back to art, starting with my opinion that art is always an open system. It is exchanging materials, energies or information with its environment, whether intended by the artist or not. With it being an open system it is important to realize that 'as Bertalanffy noted in *An Outline of General Systems Theory* (1950), the complexity of open social systems is far greater than in closed physical systems, which makes their analysis more difficult.'¹⁹ There are artworks that are static objects and aren't changed by the audience. This is the majority, but there is also art that does respond to its environment and changes, I am thinking here of performances for instance. These can also be adaptive or work with feedback. Although the last two circumstances are rare I think.

Almost all the properties ascribed to the natural system also apply to man-made systems. The main differences arise when you look at machines as man-made systems. Machines do not show any adaptive behaviour. Although since software is now regulating most machines, you could say they've started to acquire some adaptive qualities. But in my opinion you should separate the hardware (which I think is the actual machine) and the thing that operates it (the software, in this case a sort of brain).

19 Shanken, Edward A. (2009) p. 5

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Machines are one of the clearest examples of man-made systems. But also language, social organization and information belong to this group. And these systems have a lot of similarities with natural systems, including the adaptive quality.

Compatibility

Two more things to consider about the man-made system start with compatibility (or harmony). This has to do with how a system relates to its environment. This is especially important for man-made systems, which are made with a certain predefined environment in mind. The creator of the system sets the condition for how he wants the system to work and in what kind of environment. If the environment is changed, the system could very possibly stop functioning the way it was designed. Or as Hall and Fagen put it: 'Systems might be compatible in some respects and incompatible in others; it depends on the purpose for which the systems are introduced as well as the environmental factors.'²⁰ I think this aspect is important because it again shows how much the environment influences the system. That you can't separate the system from its environment. When making or considering a system you have to be aware of it. And I think this is also true for art. I think that when making an art piece you have to take into account the environment. Even if you don't want it to play a role, excluding it is still a conscious decision. So whatever you do, you need to be aware of the environment in which you place your system or art.

20 Hall, A.D. and R.E. Fagen (1956) p. 24

Assessing

In the end we have to judge the success of a system. When does it function well and when does it not? This depends on how you look at it, since it could have different outcomes from different perspectives.²¹ So this leads to optimization, because you want the system to work optimally in the circumstances you have set for it.²² It seems that the success of a system is largely dependent on how well the question for it is put. If you are not clear about what you want from the system, or where you want it, it won't function properly. Be clear about what you want is probably a universal property for a good result.

An interesting part of systems is, I think, randomness. 'In practice it is usually introduced as a factor when the variables that may affect a given attribute are so great in number or so inaccessible that there is no choice but to consider behavior as subject to chance.'²³ With art in mind, this randomness could be inspiration. The factor where you are not sure why it is, but it is in a certain way. In scientific systems they say that random is when there are too many options possible, so it becomes chance and you won't know what will happen. So here it might not match with inspiration. Of course there are innumerable reasons for a certain inspiration, but when it's there it is one very solid thought that you could call fixed. So I'm not sure if you could call randomness inspiration.

21 Or to quote the famous Johan Cruijff 'Elk voordeel heb z'n nadeel'. Translated as: Every positive point has its downside.

22 Hall, A.D. and R.E. Fagen (1956) p. 24: '...adapting the system to its environment to secure the best possible performance in some respect.'

23 Ibid, p. 24

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Synthesis of systems is much more difficult. Here science and engineering begin to take on aspects of art. A systems designer or planner not only must construct systems that work harmoniously individually and in tandem, he must also know a lot about the environment that the system is intended to match. Consideration of environmental factors requires foresight and experience; no one can ever foresee all the variables of importance and a choice of which to include is often a difficult one to make. (...) In summary, a scientist in his analysis, evaluation and synthesis of systems is not concerned primarily with the pieces of hardware that make up a system, but with the concept of system as a whole; its internal relations, and its behaviour in the given environment.²⁴

Up to now I've been following the theory of systems in a very rigid order and applied my thoughts for how it could relate to art, one to one. But things aren't this simple. You can't take a scientific text, apply it to art and make a universal statement out of it. Luckily already in 1968 Jack Burnham wrote the *System Aesthetics* text. In it, he applied the system theory to the post-formalist art movement.

24 Hall, A.D. and R.E. Fagen (1956) p. 28

chapter 2

#

#

In Bertalanffy's original description, systems are 'sets of elements standing in interaction'. More concisely expressed, system aesthetics tries to think art as a relation of relations.

Luke Skrebowski,²⁵

Burnham

Jack Burnham (1931) worked as a sculptor until about 1968. In 1960 he had started teaching²⁶ and this was what he continued to do. He became more an art theorist and critic. Additionally he was a regular contributor to *Artforum*²⁷ and curated art shows²⁸. In 1968 he wrote an article entitled 'System Aesthetics' for *Artforum*.

25 Skrebowski, Luke (2006)

26 He taught art history at Northwestern University in Illinois, becoming chairman of the art department in 1976. He took time off from Northwestern to teach at the University of California at San Diego, the School of the Art Institute of Chicago, Colgate University, and Williams College. In the 1980s he moved to the University of Maryland (College Park campus) and again chaired the art and art history departments. Now retired, he lives in Hyattsville, Maryland, immersed in Kabbalah. (source: Horvitz, Robert (2000-09) A node for Jack Burnham <http://www.volweb.cz/horvitz/burnham/homepage.html>. Online website about Jack Burnham. Accessed 24 December 2001.)

27 Alongside with Lawrence Alloway, Annette Michelson, Michael Fried and Rosalind Krauss.

28 Most known: *Software, Information Technology: Its New Meaning for Art*, in the Jewish Museum New York, 1970.

In this article he tried to explain the art movement that arose at that time, post-formalist art. He used the book by Bertalanffy as inspiration and it was only published in early 1968, although he wrote the first texts on this subject in 1950. Burnham applied the system theory to the art movement that was going on at that moment. It is quite hard to comment and reflect on a movement when you are in the middle of it. The text in its time was picked up mostly by artists. Art historians ignored it until the 1990s and, especially since 2000, the text has witnessed a revival and is used and discussed again.

In 2005 there was an exhibition at the Tate Modern in London called *Open Systems – Rethinking Art c. 1970*. Luke Skrebowski²⁹ wrote an article based on this exhibition. He wanted to 'revisit Burnham's theory and reconsider its value'³⁰. In later life Burnham rejected his own system aesthetics and it became a rather unknown theory. Skrebowski argued that by totally rejecting the theory we might have lost a tool for understanding the art made at the end of the 60s and the beginning of the 70s. Besides trying to revive it he also suggested why Burnham's system aesthetics failed: 'Burnham hinted at, but never comprehensively followed through on, a disarticulation of systems theory from its techno-industrial deployment. In so doing he only suggested the conceptual possibilities that systems theory might offer a critical art practice. Burnham too often carelessly elided systems theory and

29 PhD candidate at Middlesex University at that time of writing the article

30 Skrebowski, Luke (2006)

cybernetics.’³¹ Burnham might have left out the systems theory and cybernetics from time to time. As I understand it, the problem was that he never really made a theoretically clear distinction between the conceptual art and art-and-technology movement that can be derived from the systems aesthetics.

Conceptual Art/Art-and-Technology

In hindsight it is a lot easier to see the two movements as separate even if they have some similarities. So with the advantage of looking at the movements thirty years after they started, it is very helpful to distinguish them. Edward A. Shanken writes and teaches about the entwinement of art, science, and technology with a focus on interdisciplinary practices involving new media.³² He has studied Burnham and explains the terminology of conceptual art and art-and-technology in the following way:

Conceptual art has sought to analyze the ideas underlying the creation and reception of art, rather than to elaborate another stylistic convention in the historical succession of modernist avant-garde movements. Investigations by conceptual artists into networks of signification and structures of knowledge (which enable art to have meaning) have frequently employed text as a strategic device to examine the interstice between visual and verbal languages as semiotic systems. In this regard, conceptual art is a meta-critical and self-reflexive art process. It is engaged in theorizing the possibilities of signification in art's multiple contexts

31 Skrebowski, Luke (2006)

32 <http://artexetra.wordpress.com/bio-and-cv/> Accessed 11 February 2012

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(including its history and criticism, exhibitions and markets). In interrogating the relationship between ideas and art, conceptual art de-emphasizes the value traditionally accorded to the materiality of art objects. It focuses, rather, on examining the preconditions for how meaning emerges in art, seen as a semiotic system. Art-and-technology has focused its inquiry on the materials and/or concepts of technology and science, which it recognizes artists have historically incorporated in their work. Its investigations include: (1) the aesthetic examination of the visual forms of science and technology, (2) the application of science and technology in order to create visual forms and (3) the use of scientific concepts and technological media both to question their prescribed applications and to create new aesthetic models. In this third case, art-and-technology, like conceptual art, is also a meta-critical process. It challenges the systems of knowledge (and the technologically mediated modes of knowing) that structure scientific methods and conventional aesthetic values. Further, it examines the social and aesthetic implications of technological media that define, package and distribute information.³³

So apart from the meta-critical process, they are very different movements and it is essential to keep them apart.

It is impossible to divide artists in the one or other movement. Often their works involve both movements. But the description (of what they are/what it involves) of both is different, and even when they can

33 Shanken, Edward A. (2001) p. 433-434

apply both to one artist, it is not the same movement. 'Burnham illustrated his theory of systems aesthetics by referring to a wide range of artists, including Haacke, Smithson, and Oppenheim, whose work was not associated primarily with tech art but with environmental art.'³⁴ So maybe because he took artists who worked inside the two movements to illustrate, the boundaries became a bit blurred. Also, it might not always be such a good thing to try and put artists in a certain corner. 'The historicization of an artist's work as conceptual art or art and technology *says less about their work than it does about the institutional mechanisms that have created and reinforced categorical distinctions ... at the expense of identifying continuities between them.*'³⁵

Environment

The similarity between the two movements lies in their dealing with environment, something that stems directly from the systems theory³⁶. 'Environmental artists and tech artists both sought out and engaged in collaborations in which the artist *entered into a new relationship with the environment, space, public arena, onto the terrain of other sciences.*'³⁷ This working with the environment is the element where my interest lies. Environment is something you can't deny or avoid. Burnham had, I

34 **Shanken**, Edward A. (2009) p. 3

35 Ibid, p. 5

36 Also Edward Shanken said that 'Although their particulars differ, the terms *cybernetics* and *systems theory* are often used interchangeably and both rely substantially on information theory.' (**Shanken**, Edward A. (2009) p. 2) To put it hierarchical: Information theory is first, from it comes cybernetics and the system theory.

37 **Shanken**, Edward A. (2009) quoting Marga Bijvoet's *Art as Inquiry: Toward New Collaborations Between Art, Science, and Technology* (1997) p. 3

think, the same opinion: 'The notion that art can be separated from its everyday environment is a cultural fixation, as is the ideal of objectivity in science.'³⁸ Next to that, my work often starts with an outside element. Further, the importance of a public in a work and already having this in mind while making it seems to me to be very related to environment. Thinking about public as environment is also about communication. They are part of your environment and you interact with it/them. This is I think communication. Something to keep in mind is that although I do read the newspaper and am not totally ignorant about what is happening in the world, I do wonder how much of it is really in my work as a political something or a reaction to it. I do think that you can't really deny it. You know what's going on, so whether you want it or not, it will influence your work. But I usually try to avoid politics because I'm not sure if my opinion on it will really make a difference or is of any interest.

Burnham's theory, although taken from a very technical field, is not meant to merely apply to the art-and-technology movement. This is a mistake often made and apparently partly due to his own fault. The art-and-technology movement is not to my interest. I'm interested in how the systems theory/aesthetics applies to conceptual art, and therefore I am more interested in the theory than the visual implications.

Conceptual Art

Since my focus will be on conceptual art, I think it's good to give a second description of the movement. Conceptual art is a difficult movement to describe

38 Burnham, Jack (1970) p. 8

The Yellow Duck Phenomenon

and there are therefore many different definitions. The description that will be most important to me comes from Tony Godfrey.

*Conceptual art is not about forms or materials, but about ideas and meanings. It cannot be defined in terms of any medium or style, but rather by the way it questions what art is. In particular, Conceptual art challenges the traditional status of the art object as unique, collectable or saleable. Because the work does not take a traditional form it demands a more active response from the viewer, indeed it could be argued that the Conceptual work of art only truly exists in the viewer's mental participation. This art can take a variety of forms: everyday objects, photographs, maps, videos, charts and especially language itself. Often there will be a combination of such forms.*³⁹

39 Godfrey, Tony (1998) p. 4

A fixed set of rules on art

chapter 3

#1 ## #2 ##
#1 ## #2

#1

#1 ## #2 ## #3 ##
#1 ## #2 ## #3

No, no, artists think the same way chess players think. You know, they have a set number of rules, they make an exhaustive search about probabilities, the way the chessboard is set up. They say: 'Well I can make a move here, a move here, this is bad, this might be good.' They push it two or three moves further and they say: 'Aha, this is what I will do.' This is what recursion is. And it's ... it's really the whole basis of problem solving.
Jack Burnham⁴⁰

System Aesthetic

So what is this System Aesthetic about then. The article in *Artforum* is rather complex. This is partly due to Burnham's referring to many things that are going on at that particular time. Next to this he doesn't describe the system aesthetics as a total theory in this one article. To get a full picture of what he is saying, you need to combine at least four

40 In interview by Lutz Dammbeck (2001)

of his papers⁴¹. I will again use the knowledge of Edward A. Shanken. In 2009 he wrote *Reprogramming Systems Aesthetics: A Strategic Historiograph*⁴². Here he discusses texts that have been written about the system aesthetics. 'In general, there is growing agreement in the 2000s that Burnham's contributions to art historiography deserve substantially greater recognition and that his theory of systems aesthetics offers significant potential for the analysis of both historical and contemporary art.'⁴³

Two authors, Marga Bijvoet⁴⁴ and Luke Skrebowski⁴⁵, are mainly mentioned by Shanken. I'll be using the text *All Systems Go: Recovering Jack Burnham's 'System Aesthetics'* (2005) from Luke Skrebowski to illustrate the main points from the system aesthetics. He summarized it in five 'key insights' and gave for each a short example applied to an artwork.

41 'Burnham's elaboration of systems aesthetics is distributed across four key texts, written between 1968 and 1970. His 1968 article, *Systems Esthetics* [SE], is undoubtedly the most complete exposition of the theory. However, important extensions of its central ideas are also to be found in, *The Aesthetics of Intelligent Systems* (1969) [AIS] (delivered as a Guggenheim talk) and two additional pieces, *Real-Time Systems* (1969) [RTS] and *Alice's Head: Reflections on Conceptual Art* (1970) [AH].'
source **Skrebowski**, Luke (2006)

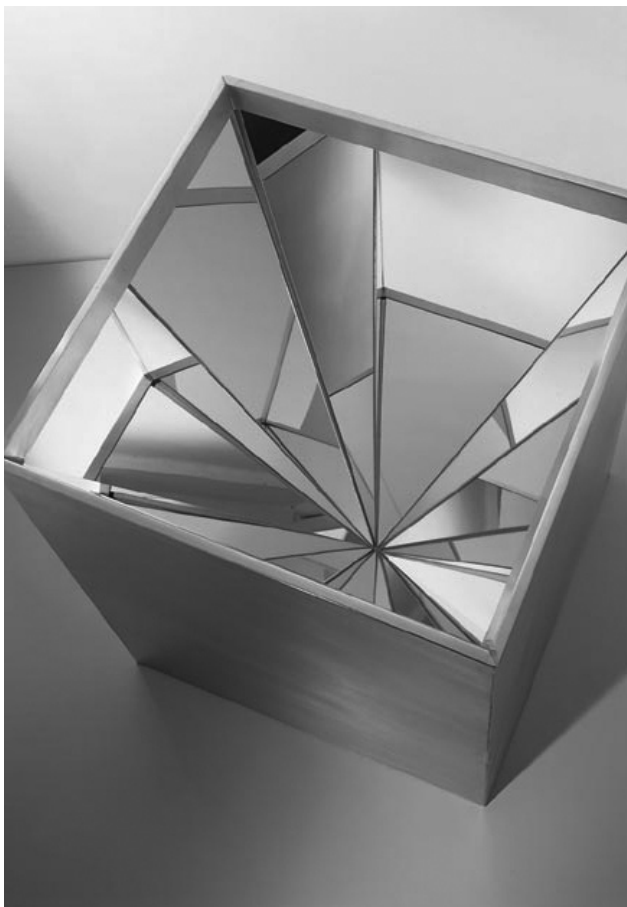
42 'This paper offers close-readings of selected literature pertaining to Burnham's "systems esthetics," the subject of significant scholarly attention recently. It identifies, compares, and contrasts several attempts to engage Burnham's theories in contemporary art historical discourses, noting strategic and interpretive shifts in approaches and goals between 1997-2009.' source: **Shanken**, Edward A. (2009) p. 2

43 **Shanken**, Edward A. (2009) p. 5

44 The text that is referred to is *Art as Inquiry: Toward New Collaborations Between Art, Science, and Technology* (1997)

45 The text from Skrebowski that is discussed by Shanken is not the same one used here. It is about how the system aesthetic and the art of Hans Haacke influenced each other, so in fact more how the system aesthetic is applied. The text used is solely about Burnham's system aesthetic, written for the exhibition *OpenSystems: Rethinking Art c. 1970* (Tate Modern London, 2005) and illustrates it with examples of art works that were on show during the exhibition.

The Yellow Duck Phenomenon



Robert Smithson

Four-Sided Vortex, 1965.

Steel and mirror 35 x 28 x 28 in.

Estate of Robert Smithson; courtesy James Cohan
Gallery, New York. Photograph by Christopher Burke.

Art © Estate of Robert Smithson/

Licensed by VAGA, New York, NY.

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A Transition From an Object-Oriented to a System-Oriented Culture

From a distance Robert Smithson's Four-sided Vortex, 1967 resembles a specific object after Judd. Yet, on closer inspection, it becomes evident that Smithson's stainless steel cuboid is open at the top, inviting the viewer to peer inside. Four triangular mirrors angle down inside the volume, meeting at the bottom. The facets set up a series of multiple internal and external reflections. The viewer is sheared into a complexity of views, destroying his or her sense of a coherent self-image. Similarly, the mirrored surfaces reflect each other, producing an optical confusion of their actual geometric orientation. Finally, an image of the outside world is also drawn inside the work where it is distorted and multiplied. Subject, object and world are folded in on each other in a kaleidoscopic reconfiguration. The individual work is forced to relinquish its claim to visual autonomy at the same time as the phenomenological frame of the gallery space is also destabilised. Here, Smithson foregrounds the relations that exist between subject, object and world by producing a deformation of them. Like the defamiliarisation visited on one's own body image by a hall of mirrors, the artist makes us think harder about our objects of knowledge. Smithson seems to crystallise the socio-scientific paradigm shift that, for Burnham, vanguard art had to respond to, namely the 'transition from an object oriented to a systemsoriented culture'^{46, 47}

46 Burnham, Jack (1968)

47 Skrebowski, Luke (2006)

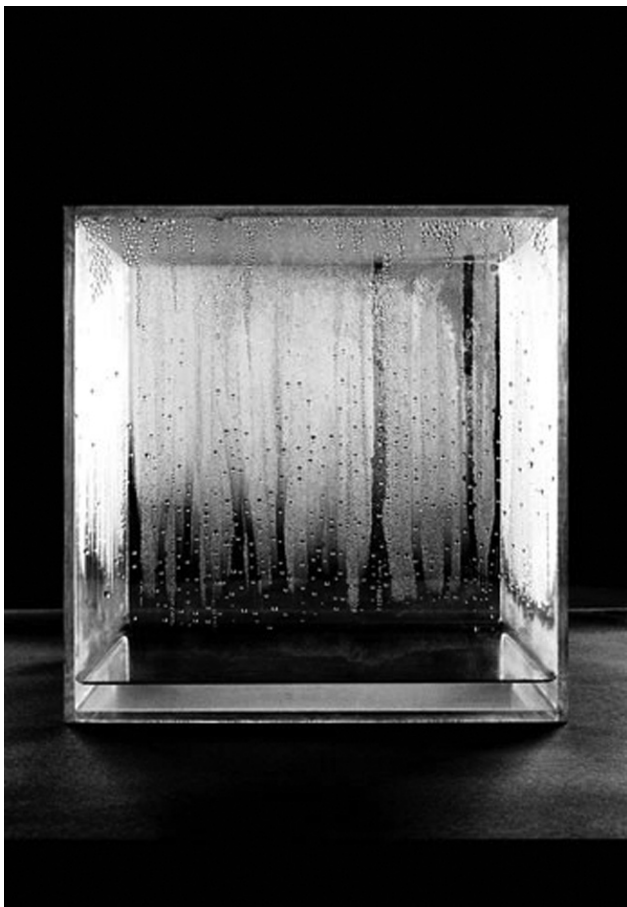
The Yellow Duck Phenomenon

It is worth to add the sentence following the previous quote from Burnham: 'Here change emanates, not from *things*, but from *the way things are done*.'⁴⁸ This property for System Aesthetic is related to the timeframe. The previous period of art was based on objects, and at that point it started to be about the concept. This shift was not only happening in the art scene, but was more a society wide movement. Conceptual art was a result and a reaction to the changing society. It is important to realize how everything exerts influence, and all the influences added up make that everything is tied to a specific spot in history. Making that you can't just copy-paste an art movement from the past and stick it on your own. Conceptual art belongs to this time frame, but I belong to another one. So whatever art movement I do belong to, it won't be conceptual art.

48 Burnham, Jack (1968)

A fixed set of rules on art explained by artworks

The Yellow Duck Phenomenon



Hans Haacke

Condensation cube, 1963-1965.

Methacrylate, water, electricity, air currents,
temperature of the exhibition space.

76 x 76 x 76 cm.

MACBA collection,

Donated by the National Committee and Board of Trustees
Whitney Museum of American Art

Art Does Not Reside in Material Entities

If Smithson fractures the specific object from within, then Hans Haacke's Condensation Cube, 1965 reveals the permeability of the artwork's apparently solid boundaries. As the gallery temperature fluctuates with the time of day, the number of people in the space and the heat of its lights, water hermetically sealed inside Haacke's plexiglass cube is moved through cycles of evaporation and condensation. Droplets race each other down the inside of the transparent box, undermining its formal austerity. An entire environmental ecology is revealed to be operating within the rarefied space of the gallery, acting on the objects it contains. With a characteristic economy of means, Haacke demonstrates the literal ways in which the gallery and its visitors affect the art object. The symbolic extension of this logic is clear. As for Haacke, so for Burnham: 'Art does not reside in material entities, but in relations between people and between people and the components of their environment'⁴⁹.⁵⁰

Two properties surface by the description of this work. The main one is that art does not reside in material entities, which means that the essence of the work doesn't lie in the form of it, but the story it wants to tell. The concept, the idea, that is what the actual piece of art is. So in that respect the execution of the work does not necessarily lie with the artist. It can be a set of instructions executed by someone else. This principle was used a lot in the 1960s by conceptual artists.

49 Burnham, Jack (1968)

50 Skrebowski, Luke (2006)

The Yellow Duck Phenomenon

In general you could say I make two kinds of work. One is investigations, simply looking or questioning what is going on or happening. In these pieces my presence is very important. It is my investigation and my view on it. Placing myself in the work makes clear that it is my subjective view on the matter.

When making objects (and getting to the point of material), I don't care who executes the piece. It could be me, but if someone else can do it better and gives better quality, and by better quality the work will be stronger, then I prefer someone else to do it. But what is essential in this is that the act of letting someone else execute the piece in my case has practical reasons, not conceptual. This is here a big difference to most pieces from the conceptual art movement.

Then in describing Haacke's cube, the relation between the work of art and its environment is mentioned. It has a very literal relationship to the place where it is. I don't think you always have to see this relationship as literally as it is manifested here. Or that it is a one-way effect, the environment influences in this case the art work but not the other way round. In site-specific work, the art piece influences the environment. This is something I am interested in. When I take the work *Stegen van Harlingen* (transl: *Alley's of Harlingen*), I took the alleys, put something in there, and by doing so changed them to enhance properties they already possessed. So the environment was both the reason for and influenced by the work of art.

A fixed set of rules on art explained by artworks

The Yellow Duck Phenomenon



Mel Brochner

Measurement Room 1969

Tape and Letraset on wall

Dimensions variable

Museum of Modern Art, New York, Committee on Painting
and Sculpture Funds, 1997

© MOMA

\$2

Art is Not Autonomous

Taking the measure of the environment that props up the ideology of the autonomous art object is Mel Bochner's strategy in Measurement: Room, 1969. Utilizing whatever space is provided for him, Bochner measures out the room's dimensions in black tape and marks up these dimensions in Letraset on the gallery wall. Taping up the gallery space has the effect of taping it off, making us acutely aware of its presence, as if at the scene of a crime. The gallery is revealed aiding and abetting 'canonical art forms,' which, as Burnham also sees it, 'place a false emphasis on physical and sensual isolation as prerequisites for aesthetic valuation'⁵¹.⁵²

Maybe it is about not using something that is truly yours. He is giving the example of Brochner, who measured the gallery space with an existing method. So none of the elements he used were really part of his design. How it differs from a readymade is I think the conceptual part. A readymade is about the object, while here it is about the act that reveals the existing object. It relates to my work in the fact that I'm not someone who is creating my unique images. In making works I usually use existing images, materials and techniques and combine them in sometimes unique ways, but always at the service of telling the story. I am not like a painter who paints images unknown to human eyes. Maybe this might be the reason why I prefer photography. I like what is there.

51 Burnham, Jack (1970)

52 Skrebowski, Luke (2006)

Homes for America

D. GRAHAM

Balletain
Brooklyn
Colonia
Colonia Manor
Fair Haven
Fair Lawn
Greenfield Village
Green Village
Plainsboro
Pleasant Grove
Pleasant Plains
Sunset Hill Garden

Garden City
Garden City Park
Greenlawn
Island Park
Levittown
Middleville
New City Park
Pine Lawn
Plainview
Plandome Manor
Pleasantdale
Pleasantville

Large-scale 'tract' housing 'developments' constitute the new city. They are located everywhere. They are not particularly bound to existing communities; they fall to develop either regional characteristics or separate identity. These projects date from the end of World War II when in southern California speculators or 'operative' builders adapted mass production techniques to quickly build many houses for the defense workers overconcentrated there. This 'California Method' consisted simply of determining in advance the exact amount and lengths of pieces of lumber and multiplying them by the number of standardized houses to be built. A cutting yard was set up near the site of the project to saw rough lumber into those sizes. By mass buying, greater use of machines and factory produced parts, assembly line standardization, multiple units were easily fabricated.



Rowing Development, first view, Queens, New York



Rowing Development, first view, Queens, New York



"The Serenade" - Cape Cod unit, etc.

Each house in a development is a highly constructed shell although this fact is often concealed by fake (half-stone) back walls. Shells can be added or subtracted easily. The standard unit is a box or a series of boxes, sometimes contemptuously called 'pillboxes'. When the box has a sharply oblique roof it is called a Cape Cod. When it is longer than wide it is a 'ranch'. A

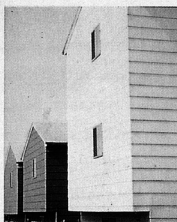


Two Serenades, Queens, New York, Queens, New York

two-story house is usually called 'colonial'. If it consists of contiguous houses with one slightly higher elevation it is a 'split level'. Such stylistic differentiation is advantageous to the basic structure (with the possible exception of the split level whose plan amplifies construction on discontinuous ground levels).

There is a recent trend toward 'two home homes' which are two homes split by adjoining walls and having separate entrances. The left and right hand units are mirror reproductions of each other. Often sold as private units are strings of apartment-like, quasi-discrete cells formed by subdividing laterally an extended rectangular parallel-sided plot into as many as ten or twelve separate dwellings.

Developers usually build large groups of individual houses sharing similar floor plans and whose overall grouping possesses a discrete flow plan. Regional shopping centers and industrial parks are sometimes integrated as well into the general scheme. Each development is sectioned into blocked-out areas containing a series of identical or sequentially related types of homes all of which have uniform or staggered setbacks and land plots.



Set-back, Sunny City, New York

The logic relating each sectioned part to the earlier plan follows a systematic plan. A development contains a limited, set number of house models. For instance, Cape Cod, a Florida project, advertises eight different models:

- A The Sonata
- B The Concerto
- C The Overture
- D The Ballad
- E The Prelude
- F The Serenade
- G The Nocturne
- H The Rhapsody



Cape Cod, Queens, New York, Queens, New York

In addition, there is a choice of eight exterior colors:
1 White
2 Moonstone Grey
3 Nickel



LAWN GREEN

- 4 Seafoam Green
- 5 Lawn Green
- 6 Bamboo
- 7 Coral Pink
- 8 Colonial Red

As the color series usually varies independently of the model series, a block of eight houses utilizing four models and four colors might have forty-eight times forty-eight or 2,304 possible arrangements.

Don Molen

Dan Graham

Homes for America 1966-7

Written and printed texts and photographs mounted on board;
each panel 101,6 x 76,2 cm (40 x 30 inch)
Dated Collection, Brussels

Art is Conceptual Focus

Burnham's insistence on the negation of the art object's materiality, autonomy and timelessness all build to his affirmation that: 'The traditional notion of consecrated art objects and settings will gradually give way to the conclusion that art is conceptual focus.' [AIS] Dan Graham's *Homes for America*, 1966-7 enacts exactly this observation. Photographs of rows of nondescript suburban tract housing along with an accompanying essay were presented as a magazine spread in *Arts Magazine*, December 1966. Graham ironically traces the serial logic of Minimalist cultural production back to the social field that occasioned it and in so doing successfully re-enunciates the art 'object' as direct conceptual documentation of the social field. The piece's artistic claim is made on behalf of its 'conceptual focus' rather than its content or mass cultural form.⁵³

The point that art is conceptual focus is something I can relate to very much. Giving the full quote from Burnham makes things a lot clearer. 'The traditional notion of consecrated art objects and settings will gradually give way to the conclusion that art is *conceptual focus*, and that the boundary conditions of form as process and system transcend the more literal notions of geometrically defined form.'⁵⁴ So the process and system (I think of the thing you want to bring across) are more important than the actual shape it will take. The final work is not only the conclusion; the whole act is telling the

53 Skrebowski, Luke (2006)

54 Burnham, Jack (1970)

The Yellow Duck Phenomenon

story. I don't take it that you don't think about the shape or that it isn't part of the work. For me it is, and to think about it is important. But only because what shape it takes will tell the story in a better way. So it is still about the thing you want to tell. The shape just needs to be in the best form to tell the story.

A fixed set of rules on art explained by artworks

The Yellow Duck Phenomenon



the worse for liquor
top heavy moon-eyed owl-eyed
pie-eyed shit-faced
snockered
shicker



featured
fortified
piffed pifflicated spifflicated
obfuscated pixilated
inebriated



hard drinker
funnel
drinkitite
emperor
bingo boy, bingo mort
dipsomaniac



boozehound juicehound
rumhound gas hound
jakehound boiled owl
whale

Martha Rosler

*The Bowery in Two Inadequate
Descriptive Systems, 1974-5*

black and white photographs and 3 panels

20.3 x 25.4 cm each

Edition of 5.

© Martha Rosler

Courtesy Gorney Bravin + Lee, New York

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No Definition or Theory of Art Can Be Historically Unvarying

Finally for us here, in *The Bowery in Two Inadequate Descriptive Systems*, 1974-5. Martha Rosler takes a series of framed linguistic and photographic representations of the then-deprived New York locale and runs them in parallel around the gallery. In so doing, she shows not only the failure of two given representational systems (words and pictures) to adequate to their object but also suggests the ultimate inadequacy of any representational system. Despite the thoroughly worked through character of his own systems aesthetics, Burnham also foresaw his theory's limitations, specifically its contingency: 'The emergence of a post-formalist esthetic may seem to some to embody a kind of absolute philosophy, something which ... cannot be transcended. Yet ... new circumstances will with time generate other major paradigms for the arts'⁵⁵. Burnham's systems aesthetics acknowledges in full the historically vicissitudes that assail any systematic aesthetic theory.⁵⁶

The last point is that 'Burnham himself placed a shelf-life on systems aesthetics, claiming that it will become the dominant approach to a maze of socio-technical conditions rooted only in the present. New circumstances will with time generate other major paradigms for the arts.'⁵⁷ He wrote it for a specific time frame and realizes that with time things will change and so will the view on it. And to say again, conceptual art is bound to a specific time

55 Burnham, Jack (1968)

56 Skrebowski, Luke (2006)

57 Shanken, Edward A. (2009) p. 6

The Yellow Duck Phenomenon

frame. But even though Burnham's theory did disappear for quite a while, in recent years it has experienced a revival and is discussed and used again.

Since we are at the point of time, I would like to add a more general note. Time has always been a fascinating subject I think. It is so unconnectedly part of everything we do, and it is impossible to disconnect us from it. What kind of influence has that on my work? I seem to have a great liking for history, for acknowledging what existed before on a certain spot. It giving an extra layer to the world is fascinating to me. I think history is time (although time isn't history). But there is also the time it takes to perceive a piece of art. In relation to that you always have to be aware of the public, and this is an important element in my work, just as the time you take to look at the work is important. Not to always set it, or force the public into a certain timeframe. Give them their freedom in it, but realize what time does to the piece. In music time is of course very much part of the piece itself. It sets a time, takes a specific amount of time. But next to this feature, Claude Lévi-Strauss gives a beautiful description of how it influences the perception of it.

*Because of the internal organization of the musical work, the act of listening to it immobilizes passing time; it catches and enfolds it as one catches and enfolds a cloth flapping in the wind. It follows that by listening to music, and while we are listening to it, we enter into a kind of immortality.*⁵⁸

58 Lévi-Strauss, Claude (1964) p. 16

Timeframe

In hindsight we can say that the systems theory and information theory were a big influence on the whole society. In art this can be seen in two art movements, art-and-technology (tech-art) and conceptual art. By respecting the differences between these artistic tendencies, while at the same time understanding some of the common theoretical threads that they have shared, we can formulate a more comprehensive account of art since the mid-20th century. Such a history will acknowledge cybernetics, information theory and systems theory as foundational intellectual models that, in combination with the advent of digital computing and telecommunications, played a significant role in shaping culture. As Burnham wrote in 1970,

*Information processing technology influences our notions about creativity, perception and the limits of art. . . . It . . . is probably not the province of computers and other telecommunication devices to produce works of art as we know it; but they will, in fact, be instrumental in redefining the entire area of esthetic awareness.*⁵⁹

Considering the moment in time he said this, I think it was rather amazing.

The systems theory wasn't totally satisfying in giving answers, and Burnham went in the direction of structuralism and semiotics. He wrote a book on it called *The Structure of Art* in 1970-71. According to Skrebowski 'Its (the book by Burnham *The Structure of Art*) rigid interpretative framework, derived from an amalgam of

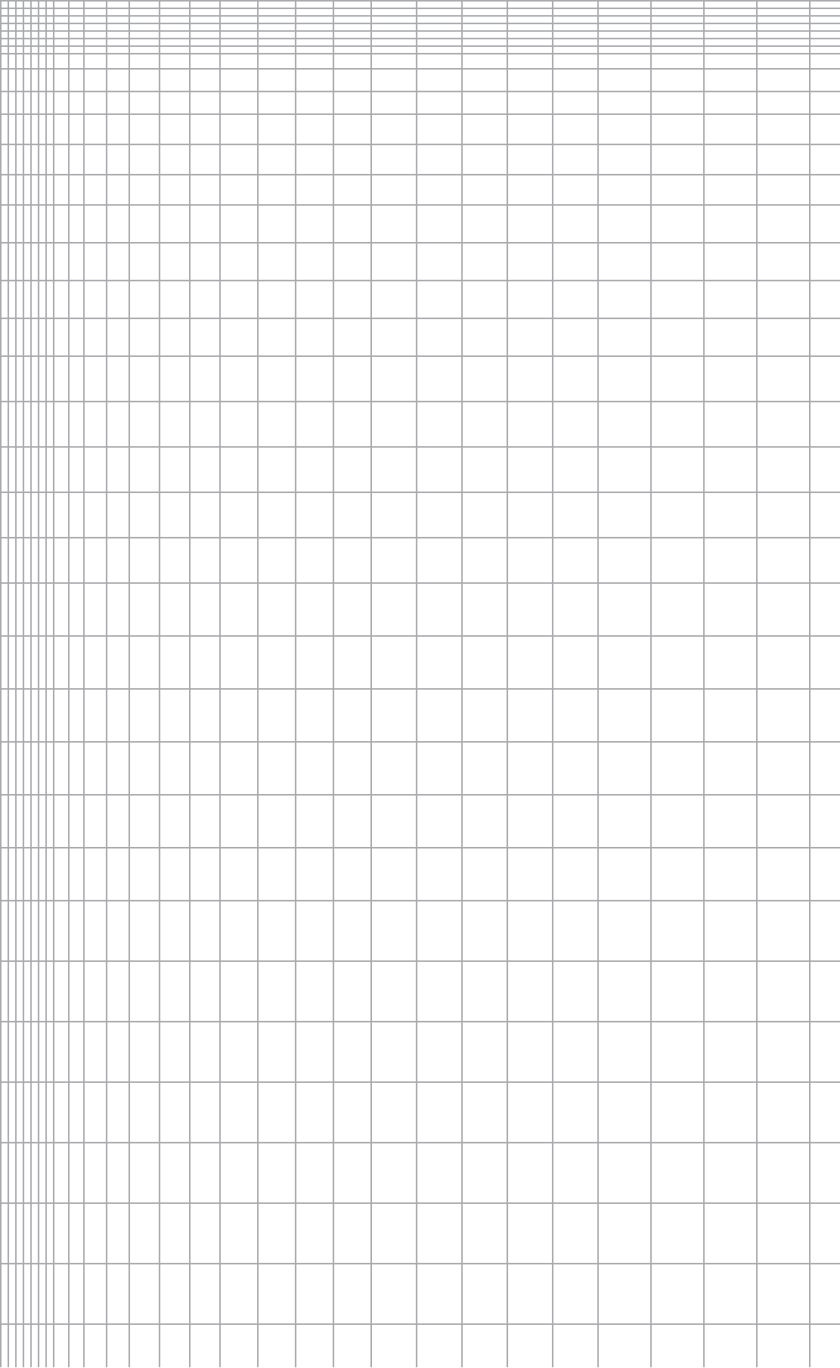
59 Shanken, Edward A. (2001) p. 438

The Yellow Duck Phenomenon

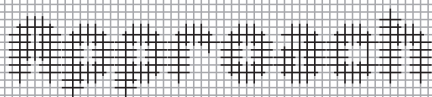
structural anthropology and semiology, collapsed the diversity and specificity of artistic practice into an inflexible Structuralist schema.’⁶⁰ So maybe it’s dangerous to go further in the direction of Structuralism, but now I’m curious, so I will.

60 Skrebowski, Luke (2006)

A fixed set of rules on art explained by artworks







Approach

After this more scientific part, we will now look at orders of a less fixed nature, starting with two texts from Claude Lévi-Strauss, one of the key figures from the Structuralist movement. Between 1969 and 1981 he wrote *Mythologiques I-IV*, the introduction to the first part, *The Raw and the Cooked*, and the epilogue from the last, *The Naked Man*, I've taken to study. These texts first explain how he wants to conduct his research and in the epilogue he discusses how it in fact had gone. It is the description of a way of working. Just like Information theory and Systems theory, Structuralism is a big subject and something I of course won't be able to grasp completely, and probably I will even misunderstand parts of it. But I don't think that is a reason not to look at it. With my way of working in mind I can look at the parts I can see related to what I do or give better insight into it. Thus I will be stealing bits and pasting them together to create a better understanding, even if Claude Lévi-Strauss himself thought nothing good of this approach.

The Yellow Duck Phenomenon

*Like writers and artists, they [philosophers] presume to appropriate them [social sciences] and, by carving off fragments according to the dictates of their fancy, produce compositions as arbitrary as collages.*⁶¹

Maybe the composition I'll create is as 'arbitrary as collages' if you would look at it as a general theory. But I'm taking parts to combine into the very specific theory of my own work. I won't pretend to put down a general theory. It encompasses nothing more than the works and thoughts by me.

This same approach I will use in studying the chapter on classifying from *The Order of Things* by Michel Foucault. He describes his work as making a critical history of thought. In this chapter he is dealing with how history has ordered its events and how humans ordered the world. He takes us through the different ways and I can see what is useful for me. Hopefully I will manage to achieve the following:

*Once the objective foundations had been reached and laid bare, artistic creation, liberated from its obsessions and phantasms by this new awareness and now face to face with itself, might embark on a new development. It will only succeed in doing so if it first realizes that not every structure can automatically have significance for aesthetic perception because of the mere fact that every aesthetic signifier is the sensory manifestation of a structure.*⁶²

61 Lévi-Strauss, Claude (1971) p. 642

62 Ibid, p. 642

Approach

So as long as I realize this I will happily go on to 'commune with the social sciences, often with predatory intent'⁶³.

63 Lévi-Strauss, Claude (1971 p. 643

chapter 2

composition

of

films

*In science there are no final truths.
The scientific mind does not so much
provide the right answers as ask the
right questions.*

Claude Lévi-Strauss,⁶⁴

Truth

According to Claude Lévi-Strauss there is no final truth, at least not in science. It is about asking the right questions. I wonder if in my search for similarities in the subjects I choose, or in putting certain things together, comparing, repetition, showing what is there... I am looking for a sort of general truth. And if there is no truth, what then does Claude Lévi-Strauss mean when he says that '(...) they [myths] make it possible to discover certain operational modes of the human mind, which have remained so constant over the centuries, and are so widespread over immense geographical distances, that we can assume them to be fundamental and can seek to find them in other societies and in other areas of mental life, where their presence was not suspected, and whose nature is thereby illuminated.'⁶⁵

64 Lévi-Strauss, Claude (1964) p. 7

65 Lévi-Strauss, Claude (1971) p. 639

Composition of Thoughts

He is finding common ground, and by finding it in one area, you can specifically look for it in other areas. This common ground ('fundamental') could I think be considered as a truth. On the other hand, maybe I am confusing truth with coherency, recurring or unity. And that this should not be considered as a general rule. It could apply it to most, but not necessarily to all. Just like when he states that 'music and mythology appeal to mental structures that the different listeners have in common.'⁶⁶ That there are things in common doesn't mean it is a truth. And indeed, when is it ever possible to say something is a truth? You can never know everything, so there is always the possibility that somewhere there exists a contradiction. Something Lévi-Straus also notices:

(..., the fact still remains that there does not exist, nor ever will exist, any community or group of communities whose mythology and ethnography (...⁶⁷) can be known in their entirety. The ambition to achieve such knowledge is meaningless, since we are dealing with a shifting reality, perpetually exposed to the attacks of a past that destroys it and of a future that changes it.⁶⁸

So there's another ambition I can lay aside. But maybe not in certain moves when making art. I think the perhaps meaningless pursuit of completeness tells a story and can be an important element in an art piece. It is common sense that absolute completeness doesn't exist, so knowingly going against this tells a story.

66 Lévi-Strauss, Claude (1964) p. 26

67 (and without the latter the study of myths is ineffectual)

68 Lévi-Strauss, Claude (1964) p. 3

The Yellow Duck Phenomenon

Lévi-Strauss almost never talks about a truth. He is saying things about underlying similarities: 'structuralism (...⁶⁹) reveals, behind phenomena, a unity and coherence that could not be brought out by a simple description of the facts, *laid out flat*, so to speak, and presented in random order to the enquiring mind.'⁷⁰

Something I like very much in the quote is that at one point he is even saying that this unity doesn't even exist in reality:

*If it has any unity, that unity will appear only behind or beyond the text and, in the best hypothesis, will become a reality in the mind of the reader.*⁷¹

I think that is beautiful, and a value I would like to put in art. So I will stick to that there is no truth, or maybe what the Dutch writer Eduard Douwes Dekker wrote: 'Perhaps nothing is entirely true, not even this!'⁷²

Unity

So there is something in unity and looking for it. This is an element Lévi-Strauss definitely talks about a lot when he describes his working method and is apparently also a key feature of Structuralism.

*Genuine structuralism, on the contrary [to mathematics], seeks first and foremost to grasp the intrinsic properties of certain types of categories*⁷³

69 It offers the social sciences an epistemological model incomparably more powerful than those they previously had at their disposal.

70 Lévi-Strauss, Claude (1971) p. 687

71 Lévi-Strauss, Claude (1964) p. 6

72 Multatuli, [Eduard Douwer Dekker] (1872). Original quote in Dutch: 'Misschien is niets geheel waar, en zelfs dat niet.'

73 Lévi-Strauss, Claude (1971) p. 627

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And in the case of Lévi-Strauss his research:

*I discerned a small number of simple principles, thanks to which a very complex mass of customs and practices, at first sight absurd (and generally held to be so), could be reduced to a meaningful system.*⁷⁴

The unity of subjects, which sometimes have at first sight no similarities in them, is a key element in my art practice. I use it at two different stages. Subjects that have this element in them trigger my interest and become the research subject for a possible work. It won't always necessary end up being an element of the final work. But in a lot of works it is still visible. The reason for me to investigate the pilgrim's route from Oslo to Trondheim was that pilgrims didn't only use this route, but it was also the coronation route. So kings travelled along it, and next to kings, it was the postal route to Trondheim. Kings, pilgrims and postmen were travelling on it, giving this same road three different meanings. Of course roads are used by many different people and for all kinds of reasons. Though while you are travelling on it, it is your road, it is there for you. The fact that this bit of road has a clear route and three clear main characters with different reasons for travel, giving the road different meanings, makes it a good place to show this element.

System

Claude Lévi-Strauss gives a more elaborate description of his working method in the following quote:

⁷⁴ Lévi-Strauss, Claude (1964) p. 10

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In order to draw my map, I have been obliged to work outward from the center: first I establish the semantic field surrounding a given myth, with the help of ethnography and by means of other myths; and then I repeat the operation in the case of each of these myths. In this way the arbitrarily chosen central zone can be crisscrossed by various intersecting lines, although fewer overlappings occur as we move further out. In order to make the grid or mesh even, one would have to repeat the process several times, by drawing more circles around points situated along the periphery. But at the same time this would increase the size of the original area. And so we see that the analysis of myths is an endless task. Each step forward creates a new hope, realization of which is dependent on the solution of some new difficulty. The evidence is never complete.⁷⁵

Again a parallel with research for an art project. Every side road you research opens up new inspiration and new roads to follow. The difficulty is when to stop going into side roads and from the whole bulk of information and inspiration you've gathered decide what is relevant and what not. What is the element you lift out of it and highlight? Because for me the interest isn't to show the whole set of connections. I research and try to be as complete as possible in finding the connections in order for me to decide which one or two can make the piece work.

Lévi-Strauss in his description sounds also very much like the definition of a system. In this case a centralized one I think that is moving towards a state of progressive

75 Lévi-Strauss, Claude (1964) p. 4-5

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systematization. So it is striving for a state of wholeness, but never getting there, since 'the evidence is never complete'. A bit earlier on in the text he summarizes it as:

*Thus is brought into being a multidimensional body, whose central parts disclose a structure, while uncertainty and confusion continue to prevail along its periphery.*⁷⁶

Another part of his study that refers to systems is the sorting of elements in objects and environment⁷⁷, or in his case terms and environments. And just as with systems he runs into the same problem, 'the problem of arriving at an unequivocal definition of the constituent elements of myths either as terms or as relations; according to the variants being considered and the different stages of the analysis, each term can appear as a relation and each relation as a term.'⁷⁸

A solution given by the systems theory is to divide the system into smaller parts.⁷⁹ I thought that this would only make the confusion bigger. But another view on this is provided by Lévi-Strauss: 'It is simplified, and its very poverty reduces

76 Lévi-Strauss, Claude (1964) p. 3

77 The definition given by Hall and Fagen for it is: 'For a given system, the environment is the set of all objects a change in whose attributes affect the system and also those objects whose attributes are changed by the behavior of the system.'

78 Lévi-Strauss, Claude (1971) p. 635

79 A tool for this could be to divide the system further into subsystems and give them a hierarchical order. The subsystems can be less complex and easier to understand, and understanding the subsystems might give insight into the main system. On the other hand, it could also provide a lot of information that is not relevant to the question at hand. And what makes this method even more complex is that objects that are part of one subsystem could be the environment for another subsystem.

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it to its essential features.'⁸⁰ So by making the problem smaller you get to the essence of it. The question, however, of how to reduce still remains. And by reducing the wrong way, you end up with the wrong essence.

Another method is coding works, substituting information for different information. Codes, even though they can be very complicated, in my opinion can make a clear representation of something complex.

*The social sciences are no doubt comparable to the physical and natural sciences in the sense that neither achieves direct apprehension of reality, but only of the symbols in terms of which the mind perceives reality in accordance with the constraints and thresholds of our sensory system.*⁸¹

Moreover, giving objects (elements, units, whatever) a hierarchy will offer insight into the matter at hand. And symbols sound very cold and impersonal. Turner has another view on this:

*The symbols and their relations . . . are not only a set of cognitive classifications for ordering the universe . . . They are also, and perhaps as importantly, a set of evocative devices for arousing, channeling and domesticating powerful emotions such as hatred, fear, affection, grief. They are also informed with purposiveness and have a 'conative' aspect. In brief, the whole person and not just the mind . . . is existentially involved in life and death issues (V. W. Turner 3, pp. 42-3)*⁸²

80 Lévi-Strauss, Claude (1971) p. 631

81 Ibid, p. 642

82 Ibid, p. 668

Aesthetic Enjoyment

With all the references to these serious sciences, systems, symbols, orders etc. the aspect of emotions seems forgotten. But Lévi-Strauss talks about how we perceive the myths, and since he often compares the myths to music he has beautiful descriptions of how we listen to music and what it does to our minds. Especially one about how composers play with our minds:

*Aesthetic enjoyment is made up of this multiplicity of excitements and moments of respite, of expectations disappointed or fulfilled beyond anticipation - a multiplicity resulting from the challenges made by the work and from the contradictory feeling it arouses that the tests it is subjecting us to are impossible, at the same time as it prepares to provide us with the marvelously unpredictable means of coping with them.*⁸³

They play with the expectations and anticipations, sometimes giving in to them and other times offering surprise, but they always stay within a certain range so as not to lose their audience. (Don't drift off too far.) According to Lévi-Strauss, 'a musical work is a sound system capable of inducing meanings in the mind of the listener.'⁸⁴ I don't work with sounds, but I do hope to induce meaning in the mind of those who see my work. I think that how he describes the substance of myths is more relevant to my work. And maybe here I even dare to say that this refers to conceptual art.

83 Lévi-Strauss, Claude (1964) p. 17

84 Lévi-Strauss, Claude (1971) p. 651

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*The substance of the myth is neither in the style nor in the form of the narrative, nor in the syntax, but in the story that it tells.*⁸⁵

Inspiration

Apart from comparing myths with music, Lévi-Strauss also takes painting into consideration. He sees music and myths as very similar but painting as quite a different field. He isn't comparing painting immediately to myth but to music. It seems he thinks music is the superior art form, but maybe I just get this impression because he talks about it most, and maybe that's only for the reason that music is more closely related to myths. He sees music as a form of art that relates only to itself. It is totally man-made and refers only back to itself.

*It is because the field of operation of music is cultural that music comes into being, free from those representational links that keep painting in a state of subjection to the world of sense experience and its organization in the form of objects.*⁸⁶

Painting refers back to the world. It can't sever itself from the subjective senses. I think he is right, but actually that is exactly the thing I really like about art. I will take what he calls painting a bit broader and apply it to art in general. I think the connection to 'sense experience' and 'representational links' make art interesting. I don't believe you can really sever yourself from the world and its impression on

85 Lévi-Strauss, Claude (1971) p. 645

86 Lévi-Strauss, Claude (1964) p. 22

you. And with music I think that on the level of sounds he is right that it can only go back on its own history. That you can't see, for example, bird singing as music⁸⁷. But in the sense of inspiration there are more sources, and I wonder if he isn't underestimating this. But when he divides music into three kinds of composers⁸⁸, we can imagine he is referring back to inspiration, and that the telling of stories can't solely relate to music. But going back to art, 'colors exist in painting only because of the prior existence of colored objects and beings'⁸⁹. It is a pleasure when things refer back to the real world. It is where we are living, it is part of us. We can't see ourselves as so superior that only culture conceived by our minds is the right thing.

Perception

So how do we see the world? How do we perceive the things surrounding us. We take them in, and here already a transformation takes place. We reconstruct them, and the form also changes by again transforming this into objects in reality. According to Lévi-Strauss we already order and structure when we see and how we store things in our minds.

87 Lévi-Strauss, Claude (1964) p. 19 'Whereas colors are present "naturally" in nature, there are no musical sounds in nature, except in a purely accidental and unstable way; there are only noises.'

88 Ibid, p. 30 'In this classification [composers according to the nature of the information they convey], Bach and Stravinsky appear as musicians concerned with a "code" Beethoven -but, Ravel too- as concerned with a "message", and Wagner and Debussy as concerned with "myth". The first use their messages to expound and to comment on the rules of a particular musical discourse; the second group tell a tale; the third group code their message by means of elements that already partake of the nature of narrative.'

89 Ibid, p. 19

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*The eye does not simply photograph visible objects; it codifies their relationships, and what it transmits to the brain is not so much figurative images as a system of binary oppositions between immobility and movement, the presence or absence of colour, movement occurring in one direction rather than in others, a certain type of form differing from other types, and so on.*⁹⁰

We see things by the relation they have to others. As previously stated: systems and structures are everywhere and we see them. The question is if we always realize so. And this brings me to a text by Foucault.

⁹⁰ Lévi-Strauss, Claude (1971) p. 678

Composition of Thoughts

chapter 2

finding

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yellow brick

*I am concerned, in short, with a history
of resemblance: on what conditions
was Classical thought able to reflect
relations of similarity or equivalence
between things, relations that would
provide a foundation and a justification
for their words, their classifications,
their systems of exchange?*

Michel Foucault,⁹¹

Foucault describes his work as a Critical History of Thought. 'A critical history of thought would be an analysis of the conditions under which certain relations of subject to object are formed or modified.'⁹²

In 1966 he published the book *Les Mots et les choses: Une archéologie des sciences humaines*. Foucault actually preferred *L'Ordre des Choses* for the original French title (this is what is used for the English translation, *The Order of Things: An Archaeology of the Human Sciences*). But

91 Foucault, Michel (1966) p. XXIV

92 This text was first written by Foucault as a retrospective view about his work for the introduction to his book "History of Sexuality", it was then given by Foucault, under the pseudonym "Maurice Florence" as the article for the entry "Foucault" in "Dictionnaire des philosophes" 1984, pp 942-944. Source: <http://foucault.info/foucault/biography.html> Accessed 26 February 2012

since this had already been used by two structuralist works he changed the title. There are two ordering principles he makes out in the chapter about classifying⁹³ that are important for this thesis – the *system* and the *method* – and I am using both in my work. The method when I am researching, the system when executing a work. Of course there are exceptions to this, but it applies to my main approach.⁹⁴ I have divided the making of a work into some different stages. I have decided to go through the text by Foucault and describe where and how it fits.

Inspiration (See)

Let's start here, where the last chapter ended, that structures and systems are everywhere, and the quote of Lévi-Strauss on how the eye sees.⁹⁵ What he describes are oppositions. The element of resemblances versus differences is also what Foucault describes as the tool to order:

(...) the threshold above which there is a difference and below which there is a similitude – is indispensable for the establishment of even the simplest form of order. Order is, at one and the same time, that which is given in things as their inner law, the hidden network

93 Chapter V - Classical episteme

94 This remark brings me to the point of rigidity. Something I have been struggling with, structuring is often seen as a rigid act. I don't see it that way, I see lots of possibilities, different options and directions and ways where it can be altered. I think in the description of Lévi-Strauss this already became a bit clear, but Foucault describes a way of ordering I see in the world.

95 'The eye does not simply photograph visible objects; it codifies their relationships, and what it transmits to the brain is not so much figurative images as a system of binary oppositions between immobility and movement, the presence or absence of colour, movement occurring in one direction rather than in others, a certain type of form differing from other types, and so on.' Lévi-Strauss, Claude (1971) p. 678

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*that determines the way they confront one another, and also that which has no existence except in the grid created by a glance, an examination, a language; and it is only in the blank spaces of this grid that order manifests itself in depth as though already there, waiting in silence for the moment of its expression.*⁹⁶

So on the one hand it is an intrinsic value of the object. On the other hand it is a value we have given to the thing and can only exist if there are also other things. If there would only be one thing, you wouldn't be able to order it.

Next to the comment about oppositions, the description of the observation by Tournefort and Linnaeus also shows similarities with some elements of Lévi-Strauss's quote:

*To observe, then, is to be content with seeing - with seeing a few things systematically.*⁹⁷

It is humans who make the whole systems and structures. It is something we impose on the world. It is our need to name and order the things, 'our divisions into species and classes are purely nominal; they represent no more than means relative to our needs and to the limitations of our knowledge.'⁹⁸ I can't help seeing the world in orders. When confronted with a problem or a question, I immediately cut it up and shift all the elements of it in such a way that it makes sense and I can give the

⁹⁶ Foucault, Michel (1966) p. XX

⁹⁷ Ibid, p. 134

⁹⁸ Ibid, p. 147, Foucault quotes here: Charles Bonnet (1769) Contemplation de la nature I (Oeuvres complètes IV, 35-36)

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best possible answer at that particular time, with the knowledge available at that moment. And hopefully being aware of what is missing or less relevant. It does feel like my head is a big piece of machinery that's shifting, turning and moving to comprehend all around. I'm making connections and finding relations in-between what I see. The relations or beautiful orders are what catch my eye and make it for a possible subject of a work. So it's not the actual order that is the subject. Orders are what make me see.

Research (Gather)

As for the research part for a work, I relate to the description of the very first historians Foucault describes. How they didn't divide their research but involved everything possible. Not to judge in advance what could be included, so even fables or stories were part of the descriptions of things.

History was the inextricable and completely unitary fabric of all that was visible of things and of the signs that had been discovered or lodged in them: to write the history of a plant or an animal was as much a matter of describing its elements of organs as of describing the resemblances that could be found in it, the virtues that it was thought to possess, the legends and stories with which it had been involved, its place in heraldry, the medicaments that were concocted from its substance, the foods it provided, what the ancients recorded of it, and what travelers might

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*have said of it. The history of a living being was that being itself, within the whole semantic network that connected it to the world. The division, so evident to us, between what we see, what others have observed and handed down, and what others imagine or naively believe, the great tripartition, apparently so simple and so immediate, into Observation, Document, and Fable, did not exist.*⁹⁹

When researching I think you shouldn't exclude anything, like in the quote with which this thesis starts¹⁰⁰, everything can be part of the work. And when the research is at a point where finding the elements that make the work and/or story possible, I can lift them out and create the work around it. I am by far not a polymath, so knowing all there is about a subject is an illusion. Of course the things I will research and dig deeper into are very subjective and related to the knowledge or interests I have. Or just the things I can see, to go back to the Greeks and their description of a historian: 'The individual who sees and who recounts from the starting-point of his sight.'¹⁰¹ Or as Foucault puts it: 'Natural history is nothing more than the nomination of the visible.'¹⁰² So everything I can see that is related to my subject is part of the research into a work. There are no boundaries, no rules or systems there.

99 **Foucault**, Michel (1966) p. 129

100 'Every possible avenue of knowledge must be explored, every door tried to see if it is open. No kind of evidence need be left untouched on the score of remoteness or complexity, of minuteness or triviality. The tendency of modern enquiry is more and more towards the conclusion that if law is anywhere, it is everywhere.' (**Tylor**, E.B. (1871) p. 24)

101 **Foucault**, Michel (1966) p. 130

102 *Ibid*, p. 132

Plan (Order)

Then, undoubtedly, I am stuck with this huge pile of things. By now I have usually managed to make a simple (although vague and intuitive) start with a very complex amount of stuff that from the outside is not quite related. Also, it is hard to see what is of the essence and what is not, and I'm usually quite confused myself at the moment. The only way out is to put it all next to each other and get it all back in line. To order them, and by the order itself see what the main element(s) are. The ordering consists of existing elements (the elements of my research). It is not done by a preconceived notion. That is why I can relate to what Foucault describes as 'the method'.

The method, (...¹⁰³) is a given arrangement of objects or facts grouped together according to certain given conventions or resemblances, which one expresses by a general notion applicable to all those objects, without, however, regarding that fundamental notion or principle as absolute or invariable, or as so general that it cannot suffer any exception ... The method differs from the system only in the idea that the author attaches to his principles, regarding them as variables in the method and as absolutes in the system.¹⁰⁴

By the act of ordering you make the theory of what puts these things together. You create your structure by the things themselves, and the things can also change the structure. Every new element added can offer new insight and change the whole set of relations of the grid, just as described when ordering plants.

103 on the other hand,

104 Foucault, Michel (1966) p. 143

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*The method is imposed from without, by the total resemblances that relate things together; it immediately transcribes perception into discourse; it remains, in its point of departure, very close to description; but it is always possible to apply to the general character it has defined empirically such modifications as may be imposed: a feature one had thought essential to a whole group of plants or animals may very well prove to be no more than a particularity of a few of them, if one discovers others that, without possessing that feature, belong quite obviously to the same family; the method must always be ready to rectify itself.*¹⁰⁵

This last passage is essential for this stage of making a work. It is a point where I have a notion of what I have and the general direction. But here is where it is possible to find the true great piece of work, as long as I am open for what the research can give and be open to change the initial thought there was about the work. This is where the piece of art has to tell where to go instead of me telling its direction.

Execute (Do)

Then comes the part of actually doing things. When I am making something, and this can be an experiment while still researching or ordering but also when it is really the end work, I act quite rigid. I decide on what I want to do and how, sometimes make small tests and then adjust a bit. But for the real thing the way to execute is fixed. I set the rules and don't change. When the result is there and I think it is not working, I change the rules

105 Foucault, Michel (1966) p. 143

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and do it again. I don't change during the making, because I think that if you do that you can't really judge the end result because you haven't been precise in doing it.

*The system is arbitrary throughout its development, but once the system of variables - the character - has been defined at the outset, it is no longer possible to modify it, to add or subtract even one element.*¹⁰⁶

The following description is also fitting:

*Adanson says, the system is like 'the trial and error method in mathematics': it is the result of a decision, but it must be absolutely coherent.*¹⁰⁷

Space

Ending where Foucault starts:

*The animals '(i) frenzied, (j) innumerable, (k) drawn with a very fine camelhair brush'*¹⁰⁸ - where could they ever meet, except in the immaterial sound of the voice pronouncing their enumeration, or on the page transcribing it? Where else could they be juxtaposed except in the non-place of language? Yet, though language can spread them before us, it can do so only in an unthinkable space.¹⁰⁹

106 Foucault, Michel (1966) p. 143

107 Ibid, p. 143

108 Passage in Borges, this passage quotes a 'certain Chinese encyclopaedia' in which it is written that 'animals are divided into: (a) belonging to the Emperor, (b) embalmed, (c) tame, (d) sucking pigs, (e) sirens, (f) fabulous, (g) stray dogs, (h) included in the present classification, (i) frenzied, (j) innumerable, (k) drawn with a very fine camelhair brush, (l) et cetera, (m) having just broken the water pitcher, (n) that from a long way off look like flies' (Foucault, Michel (1966) p. XV)

109 Foucault, Michel (1966) p. XVI-XVII

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I think art provides a similar space to the one provided by language. With the difference that art can make it visible. Language leaves more to the imagination. Although art using images might fill in the visible element, it then again leaves space for their interpretation. Both leave gaps open to be filled by the viewer/reader. The gaps might be different, but the fact that they create this 'unthinkable space' is the same. Maybe in art it is not space, but concept or thought.

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The Yellow Duck is thus the theory on my art practice. A phenomenon is something that happens and you can observe it. Doing that thesis, I have studied texts in relation to my way of working. I have gathered what triggered my interest and seemed fitting to create a view on my work. And having learned from Burnham, this conclusion is tied to the here and now. It is a view I have achieved now, with the knowledge and the works I have created thus far and with a world that is at the beginning of the year 2012. I am aware that the view I have created will not be permanent. It will change; I will change; the world will change¹¹⁰. The yellow duck I have found now will not stay yellow, or there can be another yellow duck hidden somewhere.

It is not so strange that I have started this thesis with the element that I am actually using at the final part of a work: the system. The actual work is what remains and what you will remember best. But I do want to note that systems are not

110 Or to quote Heraclitus 'No man ever steps in the same river twice, for it's not the same river and he's not the same man.'

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only the execution but also a tool during the process of a work. When stuck, giving myself some rules to do things can help move forward without having to question and confuse myself the whole time. Creating systems is a way to get some confidence or security into what I am doing, but this can be dangerous if I stop being aware of it. But when aware, it's a very useful tool.

The ways systems can move towards different stages also describe ways to order. In a system this is a result of the set of parameters, but when ordering it can be just as well a way to follow the movement of a system to get the information sorted. I am precisely thinking, for example, in the way a system can move to a centralized state. With a bulk of information you can start ordering in a way that you slowly get to a state where all the other information revolves around one centralized piece. Sometimes you are working to get things to become more coherent, and at other times you are looking for opposites. All this can be described as states of systems. In fact, I am just using it the other way round. I am the one inducing the movement of the objects, not the system. Or maybe you could argue that I am also a system.

The text by Burnham helped me bring a very dry theory back to art. To see where and how you can apply it and where I again can relate to that. Three important elements came up: my being part of the work versus works where I don't even care if I am executing it, environment, and the last one, the element of time. With all three it is impossible to give a definite answer to

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what I exactly do with it. In this thesis I just mention them as elements to be aware of. I think to really go into it was going too far into detail and defining things that can't and maybe shouldn't be defined. Art is not an exact science.

With the second part I am compiling thoughts stolen from others. It is at the beginning - first chapter - separate subjects, but with the text from Foucault it was possible to offer more comprehensive insight into what I do. But again, this yellow duck will change colour. For now I have figured that wherever you are and every place, thing, object, person is connected to innumerable other places, things, objects and persons. It is impossible to be aware of it all the time, or to know all the connections. What I try to do is lift some connections up from the web of strings and make them visible for a short time. Sometimes to judge, sometimes just to show and tell and make you realize that the world is bigger and more complicated than we can comprehend in our day-to-day lives. Systems and structures are what tie the world together.

There is no truth. And I don't mind. And no, my art isn't a system. I'm just using it.

Concluding That Ducks Never Remain Yellow



Systems Esthetics

Reprinted from Artforum (September, 1968).

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JACK BURNHAM

A polarity is presently developing between the finite, unique work of high art, that is, painting or sculpture, and conceptions that can loosely be termed unobjects, these being either environments or artifacts that resist prevailing critical analysis. This includes works by some primary sculptors (though some may reject the charge of creating environments), some gallery kinetic and luminous art, some outdoor works, happenings, and mixed media presentations. Looming below the surface of this dichotomy is a sense of radical evolution that seems to run counter to the waning revolution of abstract and nonobjective art. The evolution embraces a series of absolutely logical and incremental changes, wholly devoid of the fevered iconoclasm that accompanied the heroic period from 1907 to 1925. As yet the evolving esthetic has no critical vocabulary so necessary for its defense, nor for that matter a name or explicit cause.

In a way this situation might be likened to the "morphological development" of a prime scientific concept-as described by Thomas Kuhn in *The Structure of Scientific Revolutions* (1962). Kuhn sees science at any given period dominated by a single "major paradigm"; that is, a scientific conception of the natural order so pervasive and intellectually powerful that it dominates all ensuing scientific discovery. Inconsistent facts arising through experimentation are invariably labeled as bogus or trivial-until the emergence of a new and more encompassing general theory. Transition between major paradigms may best express the state of present art. Reasons for it lie in the nature of current technological shifts.

The economist, J. K. Galbraith, has rightly insisted that until recently the needs of the modern industrial state were never served by complete expression of the esthetic impulse. Power and expansion were its primary aims.

Special attention should be paid to Galbraith's observation. As an arbiter of impending sociotechnical changes his position is pivotal. For the Left he represents America's most articulate apologist for

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Monopoly Capitalism; for the Right he is the socialist *éminence grise* of the Democratic Party. In *The New Industrial State* (1967) he challenges both Marxist orthodoxies and American mythologies premised upon *laissez-faire* capitalism. For them he substitutes an incipient technocracy shaped by the evolving technostructure. Such a drift away from ideology has been anticipated for at least fifty years. Already in California think-tanks and in the central planning committees of each soviet, futurologists are concentrating on the role of the technocracy, that is, its decision-making autonomy, how it handles the central storage of information, and the techniques used for smoothly implementing social change. In the automated state power resides less in the control of the traditional symbols of wealth than in information.

In the emergent "superscientific culture" longrange decision making and its implementation become more difficult and more necessary. Judgment demands precise socio-technical models. Earlier the industrial state evolved by filling consumer needs on a piecemeal basis. The kind of product design that once produced "better living" precipitates vast crises in human ecology In the 1960s. A striking parallel exists between the "new" car of the automobile stylist and the syndrome of formalist invention in art, where "discoveries" are made through visual manipulation. Increasingly "products" - either in art or life - become irrelevant and a different set of needs arise: these revolve around such concerns as maintaining the biological livability of the Earth, producing more accurate models of social interaction, understanding the growing symbiosis in man-machine relationships, establishing priorities for the usage and conservation of natural resources, and defining alternate patterns of education, productivity, and leisure. In the past our technologically-conceived artifacts structured living patterns. We are now in transition from an *object-oriented* to a *systems-oriented* culture. Here change emanates, not from *things*, but from *the way things are done*.

The priorities of the present age revolve around the problems of organization. A systems viewpoint is focused on the creation of stable, on-going relationships between organic and nonorganic systems, be these neighborhoods, industrial complexes, farms, transportation systems, informationcenters, recreation centers, or any of the other matrixes of human

activity. All living situations must be treated in the context of a systems hierarchy of values. Intuitively many artists have already grasped these relatively recent distinctions, and if their "environments" are on the unsophisticated side, this will change with time and experience.

The major tool for professionally defining these concerns is systems analysis. This is best known through its usage by the Pentagon and has more to do with the expense and complexity of modern warfare, than with any innate relation between the two. Systems analysts are not cold-blooded logicians; the best have an ever-expanding grasp of human needs and limitations. One of the pioneers of systems applications, E. S. Quade, has stated that "Systems analysis, particularly the type required for military decisions, is still largely a form of art. Art can be taught in part, but not by the means of fixed rules...." ¹¹¹ Thus "The Further Dimensions" ¹¹² elaborated upon by Galbraith in his book are esthetic criteria. Where for some these become the means for tidying up a derelict technology, for Galbraith esthetic decision-making becomes an integral part of any future technocracy. As yet few governments fully appreciate that the alternative is biological self-destruction.

Situated between aggressive electronic media and two hundred years of industrial vandalism, the long held idea that a tiny output of art objects could somehow "beautify" or even significantly modify the environment was naive. A parallel illusion existed in that artistic influence prevails by a psychic osmosis given off by such objects. Accordingly lip service to public beauty remains the province of well-guarded museums. Through the early stages of industrialism it remained possible for decorative media, including painting and sculpture, to embody the esthetic impulse; but as technology progresses this impulse must identify itself with the means of research and production. Obviously nothing could be less true for the present situation. In a society thus estranged only the didactic function of art continues to have meaning. The artist operates as a quasipolitical *provocateur*, though in no concrete sense is he an ideologist or a moralist. "L'art pour l'art" and a century's resistance to the vulgarities of moral uplift have insured that.

111 Quade, E.S. (November 1964) "Methods and Procedures" in *Analysis for Military Decisions* (Santa Monica: The Rand Corp.) p. 153.

112 Galbraith, John Kenneth (1967) *The New Industrial State* (Boston: Houghton Mifflin Co.) pp. 343-353.

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The specific function of modern didactic art has been to show that art does not reside in material entities, but in relations between people and between people and the components of their environment. This accounts for the radicality of Duchamp and his enduring influence. It throws light on Picasso's lesser position as a seminal force. As with all succeeding formalist art, cubism followed the tradition of circumscribing art value wholly within finite objects.

In an advanced technological culture the most important artist best succeeds by liquidating his position as artist vis-à-vis society. Artistic nihilism established itself through this condition. At the outset the artist refused to participate in idealism through craft. "Craft-fetishism,"¹¹³ as termed by the critic Christopher Caudwell, remains the basis of modern formalism. Instead the significant artist strives to reduce the technical and psychical distance between his artistic output and the productive means of society. Duchamp, Warhol, and Robert Morris are similarly directed in this respect. Gradually this strategy transforms artistic and technological decision-making into a single activity - at least it presents that alternative in inescapable terms. Scientists and technicians are not converted into "artists," rather the artist becomes a symptom of the schism between art and technics. Progressively the need to make ultrasensitive judgments as to the uses of technology and scientific information becomes "art" in the most literal sense.

As yet the implication that art contains survival value is nearly as suspect as attaching any moral significance to it. Though with the demise of literary content, the theory that art is a form of psychic preparedness has gained articulate supporters.

Art, as an adaptive mechanism, is reinforcement of the ability to be aware of the disparity between behavioral pattern and the demands consequent upon the interaction with the environment. Art is rehearsal for those real situations in which it is vital for our survival to endure cognitive tension, to refuse the comforts of validation by affective congruence when such validation is inappropriate because too vital interests are at stake....¹¹⁴

113 Caudwell, Christopher (pseud.) (1937) *Illusion and Reality: A Study of the Sources of Poetry* (London: MacMillan and Co.) p. 111.

114 Peckham, Morse (1965) *Man's Rage for Chaos: Biology, Behavior & the Arts* (New York: Schocken Books, 1967) p.314.

* * *

The post-formalist sensibility naturally responds to stimuli both within and outside the proposed art format. To this extent some of it does begin to resemble "theater," as imputed by Michael Fried. More likely though, the label of theatricality is a red herring disguising the real nature of the shift in priorities. In respect to Mr. Fried's argument¹¹⁵, the theater was never a purist medium, but a conglomerate of arts. In itself this never prevented the theater from achieving "high art." For clearer reading, rather than maintaining Mr. Fried's adjectives, theatrical or literalist art, or the phrase used until now in this essay, post-formalist esthetic, the term systems esthetic seems to encompass the present situation more fully.

The systems approach goes beyond a concern with staged environments and happenings; it deals in a revolutionary fashion with the larger problem of boundary concepts. In systems perspective there are no contrived confines such as the theater proscenium or picture frame. Conceptual focus rather than material limits define the system. Thus any situation, either in or outside the context of art, may be designed and judged as a system. Inasmuch as a system may contain people, ideas, messages, atmospheric conditions, power sources, and so on, a system is, to quote the systems biologist, Ludwig von Bertalanffy, a "complex of components in interaction,"¹¹⁶ comprised of material, energy, and information in various degrees of organization. In evaluating systems the artist is a perspectivist considering goals, boundaries, structure, input, output, and related activity inside and outside the system. Where the object almost always has a fixed shape and boundaries, the consistency of a system may be altered in time and space, its behavior determined both by external conditions and its mechanisms of control.

In his book, *The New Vision*, Moholy-Nagy described fabricating a set of enamel on metal paintings. These were executed by telephoning precise instructions to a manufacturer. An elaboration of this was projected

115 **Fried**, Michael (Summer, 1967) "Art and Objecthood" *Artforum*, p. 15

116 **Bertalanffy**, Ludwig von (1967) *Robots, Men and Minds* (New York: George Braziller Inc.) p. 69

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recently by the director of the Museum of Contemporary Art in Chicago, Jan van der Marck, in a tentative exhibition, "Art by Telephone." In this instance the recorded conversation between artist and manufacturer was to *become part of the displayed work of art*. For systems, information, in whatever form conveyed, becomes a viable esthetic consideration.

Fifteen years ago Victor Vasarely suggested mass art as a legitimate function of industrial society. For angry critics there existed the fear of undermining art's fetish aura, of shattering the mystique of craft and private creation. If some forays have been made into serially produced art, these remain on the periphery of the industrial system. Yet the entire phenomenon of reproducing an art object *ad infinitum* is absurd; rather than making quality available to a large number of people, it signals the end of concrete objects embodying visual metaphor. Such demythification is the Kantian Imperative applied esthetically. On the other hand, a system esthetic *is* literal in that all phases of the life cycle of a system are relevant. There is no end product that is primarily visual, nor does such an esthetic rely on a "visual" syntax. It resists functioning as an applied esthetic, but is revealed in the principles underlying the progressive reorganization of the natural environment.

Various postures implicit in formalist art were consistently attacked in the later writings of Ad Reinhardt. His black paintings were hardly rhetorical devices (nor were his writings) masking Zen obscurities; rather they were the means of discarding formalist mannerism and all the latent illusionism connected with postrealistic art. His own contribution he described as:

*The one work for the fine artist, tile one painting, is the painting of the onesized canvas... The single theme, one formal device, one color-monochrome one linear division in each direction, one symmetry, one texture, one free-hand brushing, one rhythm, one working everything into dissolution and one indivisibility, each painting into one overall uniformity and nonirregularity.*¹¹⁷

Even before the emergence of the anti-formalist "specific object" there appeared an oblique type of

117 **Anonymous** (September 1, 1967) "Ad Reinhardt, Painter, Is Dead, Reduced Color to Bare Minimum" in *The New York Times* p. 33

criticism, resisting emotive and literary associations. Pioneered between 1962 and 1965 in the writings of Donald Judd, it resembles what a computer programmer would call an entity's list structure, or all the enumerated properties needed to *physically* rebuild an object. Earlier the phenomenologist, Maurice Merleau-Ponty, asserted the impossibility of conceptually reconstructing an object from such a procedure. Modified to include a number of perceptual insights not included in a "list structure," such a technique has been used to real advantage by the antinovelist, Alain Robbe-Grillet. A web of sensorial descriptions is spun around the central images of a plot. The point is not to internalize scrutiny in the Freudian sense, but to infer the essence of a situation through detailed examination of surface effects. Similar attitudes were adopted by Judd for the purpose of critical examination. More than simply an art object's list structure, Judd included phenomenal qualities which would have never shown up in a fabricator's plans, but which proved necessary for the "seeing" of the object. This cleared the air of much criticism centered around meaning and private intention.

It would be misleading to interpret Judd's concept of "specific objects" as the embodiment of a systems esthetic. Rather object art has become a stage towards further rationalization of the esthetic process in general - both by reducing the iconic content of art objects and by Judd's candidness about their conceptual origins. However, even in 1965 he gave indications of looking beyond these finite limits.

*A few of the more general aspects may persist, such as the work's being like an object or even being specific, but other characteristics are bound to develop. Since its range is wide, three-dimensional work will probably divide into a number of forms. At any rate, it will be larger than painting and much larger than sculpture, which, compared to painting, is fairly particular.... Because the nature of three dimension isn't set, given beforehand, something credible can be made, almost anything.*¹¹⁸

In the 1966 "68th American Show" at the Chicago Art Institute, the sculptor, Robert Morris, was represented by two large, L-shaped forms which were shown the previous year in New York. Morris sent plans of the

118 Judd, Donald (1965) "Specific Objects" in *Contemporary Sculpture* (New York: The Arts Digest, Inc.) p.78

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pieces to the carpenters at the Chicago museum where they were assembled for less than the cost of shipping the originals from New York. In the context of a systems esthetic, possession of a privately fabricated work is no longer important. Accurate information takes priority over history and geographical location.

Morris was the first essayist to precisely describe the relation between sculpture style and the progressively more sophisticated use of industry by artists. He has lately focused upon material-forming techniques and the arrangement of these results so that they no longer form specific objects but remain uncomposed. In such handling of materials the idea of *process* takes precedence over end results: "Disengagement with preconceived enduring forms and orders of things is a positive assertion."¹¹⁹ Such loose assemblies of materials encompass concerns that resemble the cycles of industrial processing. Here the traditional priority of end results over technique breaks down; in a systems context both may share equal importance, remaining essential parts of the esthetic.

Already Morris has proposed systems that move beyond the confines of the minimal object. One work proposed to the City of New York last fall was later included in Willoughby Sharp's "Air Art" show in a YMHA gallery in Philadelphia. In its first state Morris's piece involved capturing steam from the pipes in the city streets, projecting this from nozzles on a platform. In Philadelphia such a system took its energy from the steambath room. Since 1966 Morris's interests have included designs for low relief earth sculptures consisting of abutments, hedges, and sodded mounds, visible from the air and not unlike Indian burial mounds. "Transporting" one of these would be a matter of cutting and filling earth and resodding. Morris is presently at work on one such project and unlike past sculptural concerns, it involves precise information from surveyors, landscape gardeners, civil engineering contractors, and geologists. In the older context, such as Isamu Noguchi's sunken garden at Yale University's Rare Book Library, sculpture defined the environment, with Morris's approach the environment defines what is sculptural.

More radical for the gallery are the constructions of Carl Andre. His assemblies of modular, unattached forms

119 Morris, Robert (April 1968) "Anti Form," *Artforum*, p. 35

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stand out from the works of artists who have comprised unit assembly with the totality of fixed objects. The mundane origins of Andre's units are not "hidden" within the art work as in the technique of collage. Andre's floor reliefs are architectural modifications - though they are not subliminal since they visually disengage from their surroundings. One of Andre's subtler shows took place in New York last year. The viewer was encouraged to walk stockingfooted across three areas, each 12 by 12 feet and composed of 144 one-foot-square metal plates. One was not only invited to see each of these "rugs" as a grid arrangement in various metals, but each metal grid's thermal conductivity was registered through the soles of the feet. Sight analysis diminishes in importance for some of the best new work; the other senses and especially kinesthesia makes "viewing" a more integrated experience.

The scope of a systems esthetic presumes that problems cannot be solved by a single technical solution, but must be attacked on a multileveled, interdisciplinary basis. Consequently some of the more aware sculptors no longer think like sculptors, but they assume a span of problems more natural to architects, urban planners, civil engineers, electronic technicians, and cultural anthropologists. This is not as pretentious as some critics have insisted. It is a legitimate extension of McLuhan's remark about Pop Art when he said that it was an announcement that the entire environment was ready to become a work of art.

As a direct descendant of the "found object," Robert Smithson's identifying mammoth engineering projects as works of art ("Site-Selections")¹²⁰ makes eminent sense. Refocusing the esthetic away from the preciousness of the work of art is in the present age no less than a survival mechanism. If Smithson's "Site-Selections" are didactic exercises, they show a desperate need for environmental sensibility on a larger than room scale. Sigfried Giedion pointed to specific engineering feats as *objets d'art* thirty years ago. Smithson has transcended this by putting engineering works into their natural settings and treating the whole as a time-bound web of man-nature interactions.

Methodologically Les Levine is possibly the most consistent exponent of a systems esthetic. His

120 Smithson, Robert (Summer 1967) "Towards the Development of an Air Terminal Site" *Artforum*, pp. 36-40

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environments of vacuum-formed, modular plastic units are never static; by means of experiencing ambulation through them, they consistently alter their own degree of space-surface penetrability. Levine's *Clean Machine* has no ideal vantage points, no "pieces" to recognize, as are implicit in formalist art. One is *processed* as in driving through the Holland Tunnel. Certainly this echoes Michael Fried's reference to Tony Smith's night-time drive along the uncompleted New Jersey Turnpike¹²¹ Yet if this is theater, as Fried insists, it is not the stage concerned with focused upon events. That has more to do with the boundary definitions which have traditionally circumscribed classical and post-classical art. In a recent environment by Levine rows of live electric wires emitted small shocks to passersby. Here behavior is controlled in an esthetic situation with no primary reference to visual circumstances. As Levine insists, "What I am after here is physical reaction, not visual concern."¹²²

This brings to mind some of the original intentions of the "Group de Recherches d'Art Visuel" in the early 1960s. The Paris-based group had sought to engage viewers kinesthetically, triggering involuntary responses through ambient-propelled "surprises." Levine's emphasis on visual disengagement is much more assured and iconoclastic; unlike the labyrinths of the GRAV, his possesses no individual work of art deflecting attention from the environment as a concerted experience.

Questions have been raised concerning the implicit anti-art position connected with Levine's *disposable* and *infinite* series. These hardly qualify as anti-art as John Perreault has pointed out. Besides emphasizing that the context of art is fluid, they are a *reductio ad absurdum* of the entire market mechanism that controls art through the fiction of "high art." They do not deny art, they deny scarcity as a legitimate correlative of art.

The components of systems - whether these are artistic or functional - have no higher meaning or value. Systems components derive their value solely through their assigned context. Therefore it would be impossible to regard a fragment of an art system as a work of art in itself - as say, one might treasure a

121 Fried, *op cit.*, p. 19

122 Jacobs, Jay (March 1968) "More Les" *the ART gallery* (Ivoryton, Connecticut: Hollycraft Press) p. 27

fragment of one of the Parthenon friezes. This became evident in December 1967 when Dan Flavin designed six walls with the same alternate pattern of "rose" and "gold" eight-foot fluorescent lamps. This "Broad Bright Gaudy Vulgar System," as Flavin called it, was installed in the new Museum of Contemporary Art in Chicago. The catalog accompanying the exhibition scrupulously resolves some of the important esthetic implications for modular systems

*The components of a particular exhibition upon its termination are replaced in another situation. Perhaps put into non-art as part of a different whole in a different future. Individual units possess no intrinsic significance beyond their concrete utility. It is difficult either to project into them extraneous qualities, a spurious insight, or for them to be appropriated for fulfillment or personal inner needs. The lights are untransformed. There are no symbolic transcendental redeeming or monetary added values present.*¹²³

Flavin's work has progressed in the past six years from light sources mounted on flat reliefs, to compositions in fluorescent fixtures mounted directly on walls and floors, and recently to totalities such as his Chicago "walk-in" environment. While the majority of other light artists have continued to fabricate "light sculpture" - as if sculpture were the primary concern - Flavin has pioneered articulated illumination systems for given spaces.

By the fact that most systems move or are in some way dynamic, kinetic art should be one of the more radical alternatives to the prevailing formalist esthetic. Yet this has hardly been the case. The best publicized kinetic sculpture is mainly a modification of static formalist sculpture composition. In most instances these have only the added bonus of motion, as in the case of Tinguely, Calder, Bury, and Rickey. Only Duchamp's kinetic output managed to reach beyond formalism. Rather than visual appearance there is an entirely different concern which makes kinetic art unique. This is the peripheral perception of sound and movement in space filled with activity. All too often gallery kinetic art has trivialized the more graspable aspect of motion: this is motion internalized and experienced kinesthetically.

123 **Flavin**, Dan (with introduction by) (December 1967) *Dan Flavin: Pink and Gold*, exhibition catalog, (Chicago: The Museum of Contemporary Art).

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There are a few important exceptions to the above. These include Otto Piene's early "Light Ballets" (1958-1962), the early (1956) water hammocks and informal on-going environments of Japan's Gutai group, some works by Len Lye, Bob Breer's first show of "Floats" (1965), Robert Whitman's laser show of "Dark" (1967), and most recently, Boyd Mefferd's "Strobe-Light Floor" (1968).

Formalist art embodies the idea of deterministic relations between a composition's visible elements. But since the early 1960s Hans Haacke has depended upon the invisible components of systems. In a systems context, invisibility, or invisible parts, share equal importance with things seen. Thus air, water, steam, and ice have become major elements in his work. On both coasts this has precipitated interest in "invisible art" among a number of young artists. Some of the best of Haacke's efforts are shown outside the gallery. These include his *Rain Tree*, a tree dripping patterns of water; *Sky Line*, a nylon line kept aloft by hundreds of helium-filled white balloons; a weather balloon balanced over a jet of air; and a large-scale nylon tent with air pockets designed to remain in balance one foot off the ground.

Haacke's systems have a limited life as an art experience, though some are quite durable. He insists that the need for empathy does not make his work function as with older art. Systems exist as on-going independent entities away from the viewer. In the systems hierarchy of control, *interaction* and *autonomy* become desirable values. In this respect Haacke's *Photo-Electric Viewer Programmed Coordinate System* is probably one of the most elegant, responsive environments made to date by an artist (certainly more sophisticated ones have been conceived for scientific and technical purposes). Boundary situations are central to his thinking.

*A "sculpture" that physically reacts to its environment is no longer to be regarded as an object. The range of outside factors affecting it, as well as its own radius of action, reach beyond the space it materially occupies. It thus merges with the environment in a relationship that is better understood as a "system" of interdependent processes. These processes evolve without the viewer's empathy. He becomes a witness. A system is not imagined, it is real.*¹²⁴

124 Haacke, Hans (with statement by) (January 1968) *Hans Haacke*, exhibition catalog (New York: Howard Wise Gallery).

Tangential to this systems approach is Allan Kaprow's very unique concept of the Happening. In the past ten years Kaprow has moved the Happening from a rather self-conscious and stagy event to a strict and elegant procedure. The Happening now has a sense of internal logic which was lacking before. It seems to arise naturally from those same considerations that have crystallized the systems approach to environmental situations. As described by their chief inventor, the Happenings establish an indivisibility between themselves and everyday affairs; they consciously avoid materials and procedures identified with art; they allow for geographical expansiveness and mobility; they include experience and duration as part of their esthetic format; and they emphasize practical activities as the most meaningful mode of procedure.¹²⁵ As structured events the Happenings are usually reversible. Alterations in the environment may be "erased" after the Happening, or as a part of the Happening's conclusion. While they may involve large areas of space, the format of the Happening is kept relatively simple, with the emphasis on establishing a participatory esthetic.

The emergence of a "post-formalist esthetic" may seem to some to embody a kind of absolute philosophy, something which, through the nature of concerns cannot be transcended. Yet it is more likely that a "systems esthetic" will become the dominant approach to a maze of socio-technical conditions rooted only in the present. New circumstances will with time generate other major paradigms for the arts.

For some readers these pages will echo feelings of the past. It may be remembered that in the fall of 1920 an ideological schism ruptured two factions of the Moscow Constructivists. The radical Marxists, led by Vladimir Tatlin, proclaimed their rejection of art's false idealisms. Establishing themselves as "Productivists," one of their slogans became: "Down with guarding the traditions of art. Long live the constructivist technician."¹²⁶ As a group dedicated to historical materialism and the scientific ethos, most of its members were quickly subsumed by the technological needs of Soviet Russia. As artists they ceased to

125 Kaprow, Allen (March 1966) "The Happenings are Dead - Long Live Happenings" *Artforum*, pp. 36-39

126 Gabo, Naum (1957) *Gabo: Constructions, Sculptures, Paintings, Drawings, Engravings* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press) p. 153

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exist. While the program might have had some basis as a utilitarian esthetic, it was crushed amid the Stalinist anti-intellectualism that followed.

The reasons are almost self-apparent. Industrially underdeveloped, food and heavy industry remained the prime needs of the Soviet Union for the next forty years. Conditions and structural interdependencies which naturally develop in an advanced industrial state were then only latent. In retrospect it is doubtful if any group of artists had either the knowledge or political strength to meaningfully affect Soviet industrial policies. What emerged was another vein of formalist innovation based on scientific idealism; this manifested itself in the West under the leadership of the Constructivist emigres, Gabo and Pevsner.

But for our time the emerging major paradigm in art is neither an *ism* nor a collection of styles. Rather than a novel way of rearranging surfaces and spaces, it is fundamentally concerned with the implementation of the art impulse in an advanced technological society. As a culture producer, man has traditionally claimed the title, *Homo Faber: man the maker* (of tools and images). With continued advances in the industrial revolution, he assumes a new and more critical function. As *Homo Arbiter Formae* his prime role becomes that of man the maker of esthetic decisions. These decisions - whether they are made concertedly or not - control the quality of all future life on the earth. Moreover these are value judgments dictating the direction of technological endeavor. Quite plainly such a vision extends beyond political realities of the present. This cannot remain the case for long.

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